

Strategy, Planning and Development Committee Agenda

Date: Thursday, 18 September, 2025

Time: 9:00 am

Location: Civic Centre, Te Iwitihi, 9 Rust Avenue

Elected Members: Cr Ken Couper (Chairperson)
Cr Scott McKenzie (Deputy Chairperson)
His Worship the Mayor Vince Cocurullo
Cr Gavin Benney
Cr Nicholas Connop
Cr Jayne Golightly
Cr Phil Halse
Cr Deborah Harding
Cr Patrick Holmes
Cr Marie Olsen
Cr Carol Peters
Cr Simon Reid
Cr Phoenix Ruka
Cr Paul Yovich

For any queries regarding this meeting please contact the Whangarei District Council on (09) 430-4200.

1. Declarations of Interest / Take Whaipānga	
2. Apologies / Kore Tae Mai	
3. Confirmation of Minutes of Previous Strategy, Planning and Development Committee Meeting / Whakatau Meneti	
4. Decision Reports / Whakatau Rīpoata	
4.1 Dog Control Policy and Practices - Annual Report 2024 to 2025	7
5. Information Reports / Ngā Pūrongo Kōrero	
5.1 Knowledge Precinct Plan Engagement Update – September 2025	19
5.2 Operational Report - Strategy, Planning and Development - September 2025	47
6. Public Excluded Business / Rāhui Tangata	
7. Closure of Meeting / Te katinga o te Hui	

Recommendations contained in the agenda are not the decisions of the meeting.

Please refer to minutes for resolutions.

Strategy, Planning and Development Committee – Terms of Reference

Membership

Chairperson	Councillor Ken Couper
Deputy Chairperson	Councillor Scott McKenzie
Members	His Worship the Mayor Vince Cocurullo Councillors Gavin Benney, Nicholas Connop, Jayne Golightly, Phil Halse, Deborah Harding, Patrick Holmes, Marie Olsen, Carol Peters, Simon Reid, Phoenix Ruka and Paul Yovich

Meetings Monthly

Quorum 7

Purpose

To oversee planning, monitoring, education and enforcement activities, and guide the economic and physical development and growth of Whangarei District.

Key responsibilities

- Regulatory and compliance
 - Environmental health
 - General bylaw administration
 - Animal (dog and stock control)
 - Hazardous substances and new organism control
 - Parking enforcement (vehicles registrations and warrant of fitness)
 - Noise control
 - Food Act
- Building Control
 - Property Information and Land Information Memoranda
 - Consents and inspections
 - Monitoring and compliance
- Resource Consents
 - Subdivision, land use and development control
 - Development contributions
 - Monitoring and compliance
- District Plan
 - Plan changes
 - District Plan administration

- Strategic Planning
 - Place based strategies (city centre), functional strategies (climate change)
 - Climate Adaptation
 - Growth planning
 - Urban design
 - Strategic alignment of infrastructure
 - Reporting strategic trends and analysis
- Economic Development
 - District marketing and promotions
 - Developer engagement
- Marinas
- Airport
- Forestry
- Operational accountability of performance including:
 - Health and Safety
 - Regular reporting on service delivery
 - Compliance
 - Sustainability
 - Finance
- Reporting on capital projects.
- Operational reporting for the Strategy and Democracy and Planning and Development groups within Council where their functions are not covered by other Committees.
- Procurement – general procurement relating to the areas of business of this committee, within delegations.
- Shared Services – investigate opportunities for Shared Services for recommendation to council.
- Council Controlled Organisations (CCOs) – monitoring the financial and non-financial performance of CCOs whose functions would otherwise fall under the scope of this committee. Includes trading CCOs (CCTOs) and those CCOs exempted under the LGA. Responsibilities include:
 - advising on the content of annual Statement of Expectations to CCOs
 - agreement of the Statement of Intent
 - monitoring against the Statement of Intent
 - for exempted CCOs, monitoring and reporting as agreed between Council and the organisation
 - quarterly reporting on performance

CCO accountable to this committee:

- Whangarei District Airport – CCO

Delegations

- (i) All powers necessary to perform the committee's responsibilities, including, but not limited to:
 - a) the approval of expenditure of less than \$5 million plus GST.
 - b) approval of a submission to an external body.
 - c) establishment of working parties or steering groups.
 - d) adoption of strategies and policies relating to the key responsibilities of this committee (except for those that cannot be delegated by Council under Clause 32(1)(f) of Schedule 7 of the LGA).
 - e) the power to adopt the Special Consultative Procedure provided for in Section 83 to 88 of the LGA in respect of matters under its jurisdiction (this allows for setting of fees and bylaw making processes up to but not including adoption).
 - f) the power to delegate any of its powers to any joint committee established for any relevant purpose under clause 32, Schedule 7 of the Local Government Act 2002.

The Committee does not have:

- i. The power to establish sub-committees.
- ii. The powers Council is expressly prohibited from delegating as outlined in Clause 32(1)(a)-(h) of Schedule 7 of the Local Government Act 2002; being:
 - the power to make a rate
 - the power to make a bylaw
 - the power to borrow money, or purchase or dispose of assets, other than in accordance with the long-term plan
 - the power to adopt a long-term plan, annual plan or annual report
 - the power to appoint a chief executive the power to adopt policies required to be adopted and consulted on under the Local Government 2002 in association with the long-term plan or developed for the purpose of the local governance statement
 - the power to adopt a remuneration and employment policy.

4.1 Dog Control Policy and Practices – Annual Report 2024 to 2025

Meeting: Strategy, Planning & Development Committee
Date of meeting: 18 September 2025
Reporting officer: Zane Kumar, Bylaws Enforcement Coordinator
 Reiner Mussle, Manager Health and Bylaws

1 Purpose / Te Kaupapa

To consider for adoption the Whangarei District Council Annual Report on Dog Control Policy and Practice for 2024/2025.

2 Recommendation/s / Whakataunga

That the Strategy, Planning and Development Committee adopts the Whangarei District Council Annual Report on Dog Control Policy and Practice for 2024/2025.

3 Background / Horopaki

The Dog Control Act 1996 (“the Act”) requires all territorial authorities to report annually on the outcomes associated with key areas identified by Section 10A of the Act.

This includes the number and type of complaints received, the number of infringements issued, prosecutions taken, and the number of registered dogs and their classification status.

4 Discussion / Whakawhiti kōrero

Section 10A of the Act sets out that a territorial authority must in each financial year, report on the administration of its dog control policy adopted under section 10, and its dog control practices. The report must include information relating to:

- The number of registered dogs
- The number of probationary and disqualified owners
- The number of dogs classified as dangerous and the relevant provision under which the classification was made
- The number of dogs classified as menacing under section 33
- The number of infringement notices issued
- The number of dog related complaints, and the nature of the complaints.

Once adopted, the territorial authority must give public notice of the report and make it publicly available, which includes placing the document on Council’s website. A link to the document must be provided to the Department of Internal Affairs by 31 October 2025.

5 Attachments / Ngā Tāpiritanga

Attachment 1 - Whangarei District Council Annual Report on Dog Control Policy and Practice for 2024/2025.

Whangarei District Council

Annual Report on Dog Control Policy and Practice

2024-2025



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1 Introduction

1.1 Purpose

Section 10A of the Dog Control Act 1996 requires each territorial authority to report on its dog control policy and practices and provide specific statistical information.

This report acts as a medium for this information and is an update on the progress and processes of the Whangarei District Council Dog Control activities.

1.2 Background

The Whangarei District Council has entered into a contractual agreement with Armourguard, designated as the Council's Regulatory Services contractor, to fulfil statutory obligations under the Dog Control Act 1996, the Impounding Act 1955, and associated bylaws and policies governing animal management.

Animal control operations are conducted on a 24-hour basis from the Council-owned Animal Management Centre, located at Radiata Grove, Whangarei. The contractor's Animal Management team is tasked with delivering field services, which encompasses but are not limited to responding to complaints regarding roaming or nuisance animals, enforcing compliance with the Dog Control Act 1996, promoting responsible dog ownership and registration, and undertaking community education initiatives.

Throughout the year, the primary focus remained on ensuring compliance across all key areas, including dog registration, microchipping, and the promotion of responsible ownership practices.

2 The Council's Dog Control Policy and Practices

2.1 Council adopted its Dog Management Policy in October 2024.

The policy provides vision and guidance to ensure:

- To provide for the needs of dogs and their owners in a way that also protects the community and wildlife from uncontrolled dogs;
- Minimise the problems caused by dogs;
- Protect dogs from harm and ensure their welfare; and
- Encourages good dog ownership.

The statutory review of this policy and the related bylaw has been completed. The new Bylaw and Policy was adopted by the Council and came into force on 28 October 2024.

2.2 Fees

In accordance with the current Revenue & Financing Policy framework, revenue generated from dog registration fees, infringement fines, and impound charges are intended to offset between 60% and 80% of the total expenditure associated with dog control services within the Whangarei District, with the shortfall being subsidised by general rates. The Council offers a reduced registration fee for owners of classified "working dogs," as well as for those who have had their dogs de-sexed. Additionally, dogs designated as "disability assist" are exempt from registration fees.

Fees are used for:

- Responding to complaints, conducting patrols, and enforcing dog-related regulations.
- Preventing dog-related incidents by identifying unregistered dogs, disqualifying irresponsible owners, and managing classifications for menacing or dangerous dogs.
- Administering the yearly dog registration renewal process.
- Installing signage to support the Council's Dog Management Policy and Bylaw.
- Operating dog shelter services, including reuniting lost pets with owners and facilitating adoptions.
- Delivering educational initiatives for schools and community organizations.

3 Key Achievements 2024/2025

3.1 Responding to complaints (Requests)

Dog related complaints and requests for service increased by 24% from last year. There were 4,187 dog control service requests over the 2024/2025 period, compared to 3,390 from the year before.

3.2 Enforcement Activities

There were 2,067 infringements issued for offences under the Dog Control Act in 2024/25. This represents just over an 8% increase from the 1,908 infringements issued in 2023/2024.

Dog attacks decreased by 9 to 170 attacks this year, compared to 179 last year. This result reflects the positive impact the decision made by Council to enhance dog control services back in July 2021 is having. Total attack numbers are still substantially lower than the 2016/2017 to 2019/2020 reporting periods.

As per the previous year and going forward, dog registration has, and will continue to be, a heightened area of focus, as unregistered dogs are still disproportionately involved in breaches under the Act.

The standard of investigative work and case documentation produced by the contractor's officers has continued to improve, resulting in an increased use of alternative enforcement measures. This trend is attributable to the proactive involvement of the Animal Management team, which has been effective in preventing incidents before escalation. It also reflects the positive impact of Council-led enhancements to dog control services, which have enabled staff to conduct proactive patrols and follow up on instances of non-compliance with the Dog Control Act 1996 and relevant bylaws. Most importantly, the attacks that were reported were of a relatively minor nature and as a result, no prosecutions were initiated during the reporting period.

3.3 New Animal Shelter (Dog Pound)

In November 2024, the Council opened its newly completed Animal Management Shelter, marking a major step forward in the delivery of animal services across the district. This purpose-built facility was developed to meet growing community needs and to ensure full compliance with the Council's obligations under the Dog Control Act 1996, the Impounding Act 1955, and related animal welfare legislation. Designed with functionality, safety, and animal wellbeing in mind, the shelter significantly improves the Council's ability to carry out its legal responsibilities. It provides a clean, secure, and well-organized environment for the care and management of dogs, including those that are lost, impounded, or awaiting adoption. The facility includes dedicated quarantine zones to help prevent the spread of disease, as well as specially designed areas for puppies, ensuring they receive appropriate care in a safe and hygienic setting.

The new shelter also supports more efficient enforcement of animal management bylaws and policies, enabling staff to respond more effectively to incidents and community concerns. With improved infrastructure and resources, the Council is better equipped to promote responsible dog ownership, protect public safety, and uphold high standards of animal welfare.

This investment reflects the Council's commitment to providing a modern, responsive, and community-focused animal management service.

3.4 Menacing Dogs

Under the provisions of the Dog Control Act 1996, all dogs must be classified as menacing if they belong to a breed or type listed in Schedule 4 of the Act, or if the territorial authority determines that the dog poses a risk to individuals, other animals, or wildlife due to its behaviour. Dogs that have been classified as menacing are required to be de-sexed and must wear a muzzle when in public spaces. The de-sexing of menacing dogs is recognised as a critical measure in mitigating dog-related harm within the community.

During the year, 46 further dogs have been classified in the district as menacing dogs under Section 33C of the Act. These dogs are of the American Pitbull Terrier type. The number of dogs that are classified as menacing based on reported behaviour increased by 4 to 37 in 2024/25 year from 33 the previous year. This brings the total number of menacing dogs in the district to 268.

The Dog Control Act 1996 provides the Council with a tiered enforcement framework to support compliance with dog classification requirements. This mechanism continues to be actively utilized by the Council to address non-compliance. Furthermore, the Act empowers the Council to seize dogs that repeatedly fail to meet compliance standards. In such cases, the Council undertakes active decision-making regarding the future placement of the dog, particularly where ongoing non-compliance is a concern.

3.4 Other Achievements

Dog registration continues to be a highlighted area of focus for the team. The number of registered dogs increased by 4.8% percent from 12,296 in 2023/2024 to 12,889 in 2024/2025. The numbers of registered dogs are expected to keep increasing, as the district grows.

Infringements issued for non-registration increased by 207 infringements, from 1,673 issued in 2023/2024 to 1,880 in 2024/2025. This reflects an emphasis on actively disincentivising registration avoidance, as this behaviour increases the burden on law abiding dog owners who ensure their registration is kept up to date. This is also the highest number of infringements issued for this type of offence since reporting began in the 2016/2017 year. More importantly however, it penalizes those dog owners who are not "responsible" and don't do the right thing, which assists Council in keeping future costs down for responsible dog owners.

The contractual enhancement since July 2021 has allowed Animal Management to respond to more service requests and conduct more proactive enforcement. This is shown in an increase in service requests, coupled with a demonstrated increase in enforcement activity, including notably registration enforcement, all of this points to effective earlier intervention and gains being achieved, along with members of the public being more willing to report dog related matters to Animal Management.

Whangarei Animal Management has again offered another year of dog education programs to all 47 Primary & Intermediate Schools within the Whangarei area. Schools from both urban and rural zoning took the opportunity to participate in this program including:

- Kaurihohore Primary School
- Ruakaka Primary School
- Waiotiroa Primary School
- Matarau Primary School
- Raurimu Primary School
- Purua School

This program is presented by Whangarei Animal Management's School Education dog "Max", who is accompanied by an Animal Management Officer. "Max" is a docile Labrador who enjoys the interactions with each student. Although his large size and presence of a face muzzle can be frightening, on first sign, for some students, quickly his calming manner becomes an

essential learning tool. During the presentation, “Max” demonstrates canine body language, the benefits of muzzle training, full control when handling a dog and basic dog training skills.

Along with these visual aids from “Max”, the Animal Management officer discusses examples of dangerous dog situations and how the risk can be minimized by the students, if encountering an uncontrolled dog. These situations include asking permission to pat a dog, giving distance when a dog is eating as well as creating a safe distance between yourself and a roaming dog.

For the past two years Whangarei Animal Management has utilized “The Dog Box” which was essentially a gift box to each classroom created by the Department of Internal Affairs (DIA) to enhance the visual learning. This box included multiple colouring in sheets and a large interactive board game. Unfortunately, “The Dog Box” has been discontinued by the DIA and will no longer be available to offer.

Although this news is devastating, Whangarei Animal Management and “Max” will continue to offer their educational program to the young students of Whangarei.

3.5 *Planned Activities for 2025/2026*

- 3.5.1 Maintain emphasis on timely and thorough interventions for behaviours such as roaming and aggression, aiming to sustain and build upon the progress made in reducing incidents like dog attacks and rushing.
- 3.5.2 Continue expanding proactive efforts by the contractor to address unregistered dogs.
- 3.5.3 Sustain collaboration with local schools to deliver dog safety education and resources, with a particular focus on reaching high-risk area. Early outcomes have been encouraging, with positive feedback from participating schools.
- 3.5.4 Maintain a strong focus on identifying and classifying dogs based on breed or reported behaviour, ensuring all necessary classifications are completed to support responsible dog management.
- 3.5.5 Continue exploring innovative strategies to improve adoption rates and connect more dogs with suitable homes.

4 *Summary*

Armourguard, the Council's Regulatory Enforcement contractor, has now served as the Animal Management provider for the Whangarei District for nearly nine years. The Animal Management team continues to prioritise responsible dog ownership, with a strong focus on registration, compliance, and enforcement activities.

A significant milestone was achieved with the opening of the new animal (dog) shelter, which is now operational. This modern facility has already begun to enhance service standards and improve outcomes for both the community and the animals in Council care.

Looking forward to the year 2025/2026, the Animal Management team will maintain its commitment to continuous improvement, with a particular emphasis on operational consistency and delivering greater value to the community.

5 Dog Control Statistics

5.3 Table one: Registration/Classification related data

	Total 2024/25
Dogs Registered	12,889
Dog Owner Classification	
Probationary	5
Disqualified	11
Menacing Classification	
By Breed	46
By Deed	37
Combined	83
Dangerous Classification	
Section 31(1) a	0
Section 31(1) b	1
Section 31(1) c	0
Total Dangerous	1

5.4 Table two: Service data

Breakdown by job type

Job Type	2024/2025
Wandering	1243
Barking	1330
Attacks	170
Rushing	97
Unregistered Dog Check	743
Miscellaneous*	604
Grand total	4,187

*Miscellaneous: Reactive and proactive patrols, worrying/trapping, fouling, condition check, miscellaneous bylaw breach

5.5 Table three: Compliance Data

	2024/2025
Prosecutions	
Number of people prosecuted (note there may be more than one charge)	Concluded (Successful) = 0 Concluded Total = 0 Commenced but not concluded in the period = 0
Infringement offence	
18 Wilful Obstruction of dog control officer or ranger	3
19(2) Failure or refusal to supply information or wilfully providing false particulars	0
19A (2) Failure to supply information or wilfully provide false about dog	0
20(5) Failure to comply with any bylaw authorised by the section	0
23A (2) Failure to undertake dog owner education program of dog obedience course (or both)	0
24 Failure to comply with the obligations of a probationary owner	0
28(5) Failure to comply with the effects of disqualification	5
32(2) Failure to comply with the effects of classification of dog as dangerous	1
32(4) Fraudulent sale or transfer of dangerous dog	0
33EC (1) Failure to comply with the effects of classification of dog as menacing	23
33F (3) Failure to advise person of muzzle and leashing requirements	0
36A (6) Failure to implant microchip transponder in dog	28
41 False statement in relation to dog registration	1
41A Falsely notifying death of dog	1

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42 Failure to register dog	1880
46(4) Fraudulent procurement or attempt to procure replacement dog registration label or disc	0
48(3) Failure to advise change of dog ownership	0
49(4) Failure to advise change of address	1
51(1) Removal, swapping or counterfeiting of registration label or disc	0
52A Failure to keep dog controlled or confined	61
53(1) Failure to keep dog under control	50
54(2) Failure to provide proper care and attention, to supply proper and sufficient food, and to provide adequate exercise	0
54A Failure to carry leash in public	0
55(7) Failure to comply with barking dog abatement notice	1
62(4) Allowing dog known to be dangerous to be at large unmuzzled or unleashed	0
62(5) Failure to advise of muzzle and leashing requirements	0
72(2) Releasing dog from custody	1
Grand total	2,067

5.1 Knowledge Precinct Plan Engagement Update – September 2025

Meeting: Strategy, Planning and Development meeting
Date of meeting: Thursday 18 September 2025
Reporting officer: Lucy Edwards (Strategic Urban Designer)

1 Purpose / Te Kaupapa

To update the Committee on the development process of the Knowledge Precinct Plan, present feedback received from the first round of engagement and outline the next steps for the project.

2 Recommendation/s / Whakataunga

That the Committee:

1. Notes the report and Attachment 1 'Knowledge Precinct Plan – First Round of Engagement Summary Report July 2025'.

3 Background / Horopaki

The Knowledge Precinct Plan is a 30-year plan which covers the area surrounding the civic functions of Te Iwitahi, Forum North and the Library, and includes important spaces such as Cafler Park, Waiarohia Stream, Forum North and surrounding areas. This is a non-statutory plan that will be developed through hapū and community engagement, to set a vision and key objectives for the area. Precinct Plans also include a range of actions delivered over the long-term either by Council or by other partners or the community.

In May 2025, Whangarei District Council staff undertook the first of two rounds of public engagement on the Knowledge Precinct Plan. Staff have now analysed the feedback received during this engagement period and have prepared a Summary Report (Attachment 1).

4 Discussion / Whakawhiti kōrero

4.1 Engagement methods

The first round of engagement for the Knowledge Precinct Plan comprised:

- an online survey;
- four drop-in information sessions; and
- letters and emails to landowners and businessowners within the Precinct.

4.2 Engagement response summary

165 survey responses were completed and staff spoke to over 90 people across the drop-in sessions. Meetings and workshops were held with individuals and community groups who own or use land within the Precinct. These included:

- the Youth Advisory Group;
- the Positive Aging Advisory Group and the Disability Advisory Group;
- Whangārei Intermediate School;
- Whangārei Multi Ethnic Collective;
- Northpower;
- Kainga Ora;
- Creative Northland; and
- nine landowners/businessowners/Precinct stakeholders.

A detailed breakdown of survey responses and the demographic data of those who completed the survey can be found in Attachment 1.

The feedback is useful for painting a picture of how the community currently use the spaces within the Knowledge Precinct; what they would like to see here in the future; and their thoughts on a knowledge, education and arts hub and a new theatre.

4.3 Tertiary hub feedback

64% of respondents either strongly supported or supported the establishment of a tertiary education hub in the city centre. 16% either opposed or strongly opposed. People generally felt that this would be great for Whangārei. The most frequent reasons given were that:

- it would revitalise the city centre;
- it would give people the option to stay here rather than leave for education; and
- that it would benefit future generations/attract young people.

Some respondents expressed concerns about whether or not such a project would work. In particular, some people felt that:

- significant infrastructure would be required to support it (such as accommodation, parking and/or other transport options);
- it would have a negative impact on existing parking and traffic issues;
- Whangārei already has a tertiary campus and doesn't need another one; and that
- this was not a suitable location for a campus.

Some ideas that respondents had for the tertiary hub included:

- moving Northtec into the Precinct;
- making sure it includes arts education and exhibition spaces;
- ensuring the site is still publicly accessible; and
- ensuring the Precinct includes student accommodation.

4.4 Theatre feedback

72% of respondents either strongly supported or supported a new, larger theatre for Whangārei. 15% either opposed or strongly opposed. Reasons for support included:

- the city wants to attract a broader range of performance and arts events; and
- it would benefit future generations and the wider community in general.

As with a tertiary hub, some concerns were raised about parking and accessibility associated with a new theatre. Ideas for a new theatre included:

- ensuring there were smaller performance spaces as well as the new large one; and
- considering the waterfront as an alternative location for a theatre.

4.5 Costs and other concerns

There were several comments expressing concerns about the cost of such a project, including that:

- Ratepayers should not pay for the project;
- Council money should not be spent on this work and was better spent on more pressing issues; and that
- this was an unnecessary vanity project.

4.6 Wider Precinct area opportunities

There was a sense across responses that there were many positive features about the Knowledge Precinct area. These included:

- the Central Library;
- recent improvements to Cafler Park, including Lovers Lane;
- proximity to a range of shops and services;
- parking options; and
- the Old Library.

More opportunities existed to provide a safe and thriving central city space for the community. Some of the issues people want to see addressed through the Plan include:

- safety, including safety at night and safety around vehicles;
- poor connectivity for pedestrians and cyclists between shared paths and green spaces; and
- the lack of activities and spaces for the whole community, particularly young people and children.

4.7 Draft Strategic Framework and Feedback Alignment

Through the workshops that were held with elected members, the Project Steering Board, hapū and WDC staff in 2024, the following draft Strategic Framework was developed:

Vision					
The centre for learning, arts, culture and community in the heart of Whangārei					
Values					
Auahatanga Innovative, creative and forward-thinking approaches to development.		Mauri Tū Prioritising approaches to development that revitalise and enhance the mauri of the natural environment and people.		Mahitahi Working together in partnership to achieve our shared goals.	
Outcomes					
Knowledge Mātauranga The Precinct promotes education, training, and hapū mātauranga, creating opportunities for economic growth, through industry and employment, including mahi tiaki taiao.	Community Hapori The Precinct is for the community, and offers a range of co-located civic spaces, opportunities for local business, housing, health services, spaces for youth, recreation, arts and culture.	Experience Wheako The Precinct celebrates the arts, is a catalyst for regional economic development, and is a major cultural destination in Northland for residents and visitors.	Connectivity Tūhonohono The Precinct is safe & accessible to all ages and abilities, and well-connected to multiple transport modes across Whangārei and the wider region.	Resilience Waiora Mauri is restored in the Precinct, from the Waiarohia stream and the surrounding corridor, protecting and enhancing the wider environment and its resilience.	Identity Tuakiri The Precinct reflects our distinctive identity and unique sense of place in Whangārei.
Key Moves					
1. A Hub for the Community Transform Forum North into a regional hub that enriches community life through knowledge, education, and the arts.	2. The Green Frame Expand Botanica into Cafler Park and along the stream corridor, creating a resilient, beautiful environment for the public and visitors to enjoy.	3. Gateways and Access Create a regional transport nexus that connects people seamlessly from arrival to a destination of experiences, with safe, convenient transfers, shared paths and footpaths.	4. Mana i te Whenua Strengthen hapū connections within the Precinct.	5. An Integrated Precinct Connect with the city and sustain the Precinct with a mix of amenities and services.	

It is encouraging to see that there is already strong alignment with the draft strategic framework and the feedback received from the community. For example:

- There is a strong desire to see the Forum North site put to good use for the community;
- The community want to see transport matters addressed, including providing a range of safe and convenient transport options;
- Cafler Park is a valued community space and there are opportunities to celebrate and expand on this; and
- The Precinct is conveniently located and future development must strengthen its connection to other parts of the central city.

Feedback received from the community that will help further shape key moves, and specific actions that will underpin these key moves, include:

- Providing a range of performing arts spaces to suit a range of needs;
- Improving the Old Library to enhance this as a valuable community space, particularly for children and youth; and
- Incorporating adaptable community spaces, both indoor and outdoor, that are safe and can be used for a range of purposes.

4.8 Wider Knowledge Precinct programme and Feedback Alignment

Feedback that will help to inform the wider programme, particularly opportunities relating to tertiary education, include:

- Providing a range of qualifications and study options that make Whangārei a desirable and unique place to study;
- Providing accommodation and other support services to enhance the student experience and support transitions between education and employment; and
- Ensuring coordination with other existing tertiary providers around the region.

4.9 Next steps

At the time of writing, staff are also preparing a decision paper to Council to consider funding from Forum North Trust to procure professional services that will progress the Lyric theatre and inform the Precinct Plan. Staff also continue to work internally and externally to understand issues and deliverables within the Precinct. A particular focus has been on Cafler Park this month.

A key next step for Council staff is to develop a draft Knowledge Precinct Plan, which incorporates the opportunities and concerns raised by the community. This will be shared with the community as part of the second round of public engagement. Staff continue to work with the appointed Project Steering Board to further understand key partnerships and outcomes that the Precinct could help to deliver. The key external relationships and negotiations sit with the Project Steering Board (PSB of which a Chairman's update report was presented to Council last month.

The Precinct Plan is part of a wider programme of work which is progressing. Pending revised Council budgets, key steps for the next few months of the programme are:

- MoSCoW (Must do, Should do, Could do and Won't do) prioritisation analysing initiatives within the programme according to: must-have, should-have, could-have, and won't-have, or will not have right now.
- Masterplan brief and masterplan options (Theatre led vs Precinct led vs City led)
- Economic wellbeing analysis
- Viability & market lens
- Economic case, delivery and programme business case
- Delivery strategy

5 Financial/budget considerations

Public engagement is a fundamental component of every strategic plan or strategy and is therefore scoped into work programmes. Each of the public engagement activities was work delivered within the Strategic Planning Department budget and done with staff time.

The delivery of the Precinct Plan actions will need to continue to undergo further Council decisions as well as necessary business cases or financial decisions. A Programme Business Case process is underway to support Council to understand the costs and benefits from this work overall – but detail will remain with the individual projects.

6 Policy and planning implications

While Precinct Plans are non-statutory documents, the Knowledge Precinct is identified as a Transformational Move in the Whangārei Future Development Strategy (adopted May 2025). The Knowledge Precinct Plan may also shape future iterations of the District Plan, inform the Long Term Plan and inform resource consenting processes, private landowner and investor actions, central government agency responses and other decisions for this part of the city centre.

7 Options

To:

1. Note report; or
2. Not note the report.

7.1 Risks

By not noting the report, Council risks the perception from the community that their input is not valued. Community input is critical for shaping Precinct Plans and this feedback has provided useful insights into what the objectives of the Knowledge Precinct Plan could be.

8 Significance and engagement / Te Hira me te Arawhiti

This specific agenda presents the engagement process and findings from the first round of community engagement. The public will be informed via agenda publication on the website. While the decisions or matters of this agenda do not trigger the significance criteria outlined in Council's Significance and Engagement Policy, future decisions relating to the Knowledge Precinct Plan will likely trigger significance criteria, and as such will undergo appropriate consultation and processes.

9 Attachments / Ngā Tāpiritanga

Attachment 1 – Knowledge Precinct Plan – First Round of Engagement – Summary Report
July 2025

Knowledge Precinct Plan First Round of Engagement

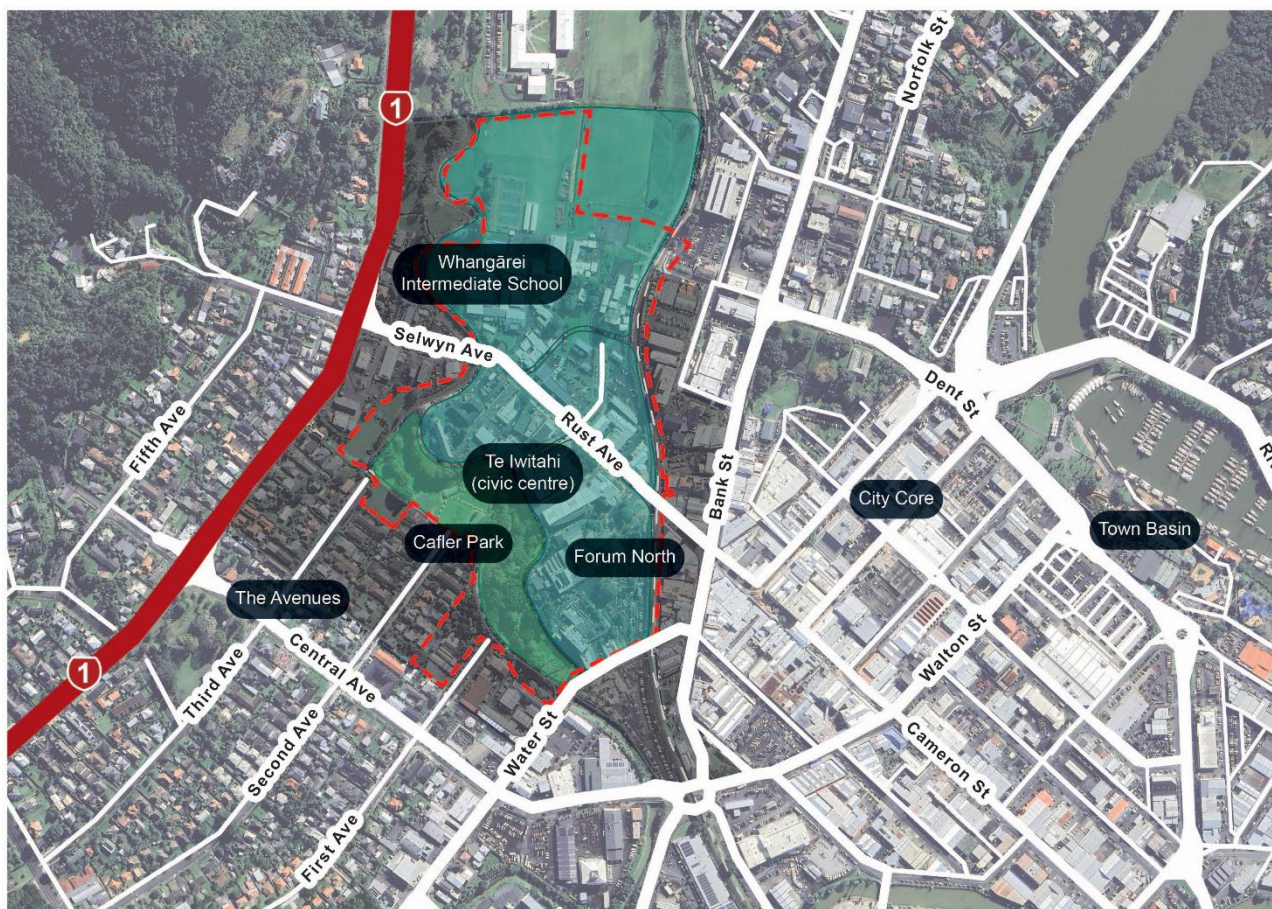
Summary Report

July 2025

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1 Executive summary

The Knowledge Precinct Plan is a 30-year plan for the part of the city centre around Rust Avenue, including Cafler Park, Forum North, the Central and Old Library, and Te Iwitihi (Civic Centre).



The development of a Precinct Plan is a collaborative process and understanding the community's needs, interests and concerns is vital to its success. The first of two rounds of public engagement for the Knowledge Precinct Plan was undertaken in May 2025. This was achieved through:

- an online survey;
- Four drop-in information sessions; and
- letters and emails to landowners and businessowners within the Precinct

165 survey responses were completed and staff spoke to over 90 people across the drop-in sessions. Nine meetings and workshops were held with individuals and community groups who own or use land within the Precinct.

Overall, feedback showed the community was supportive of a Knowledge Precinct. Generally, people felt that a Precinct that provided a tertiary hub and bigger and/or improved arts facilities would benefit the community, including future generations. Some respondents expressed concerns about the cost of such a project; and how the infrastructure to support it (such as accommodation, parking and access) would be provided. Issues that people wanted to see addressed through the Plan included safety and the provision of activities and spaces for the whole community, particularly young people and children.

There was a sense across responses that there were many positive features about the Knowledge Precinct area such as the Central Library and Lovers Lane; but that more opportunities existed to provide a safe and thriving central city space for the community.

2 *First round of engagement - Overview*

The Precinct Planning process is a collaborative process. Engagement and support from the community, tangata whenua and key external stakeholders are critical factors to the success of the project.

For the Knowledge Precinct Plan, the process to develop the plan consists of two stages of community engagement. This report provides a summary of feedback from the first round. The second round of engagement will seek feedback on a draft Precinct Plan.

The purpose of the first round of engagement was to:

- Inform the community that Council is in the early stages of developing a Precinct Plan for the area around Rust Avenue and including Botanica and Cafler Park;
- Inform the community that there is interest in developing a tertiary education and arts hub for Whangārei in this location;
- Provide an overview of the community engagement process and how the community can be involved;
- Gauge general support for a new, larger theatre and a knowledge, education and arts hub;
- Understand how the community currently use the area;
- Find out what the community likes and dislikes about the area; and
- Find out the community's general aspirations for the area.

The first round of community engagement consisted of:

- An online survey available on WDC's 'Have Your Say' webpage (a copy of the survey is available in Appendix 1);
- Four drop-in sessions, three at the Central Library and one at the Whangārei Growers Market;
- Letters and emails sent to landowners and businessowners within the Precinct inviting them to meet with staff to discuss the plan. Nine meetings and workshops were held with individuals and community groups who own or use land within the Precinct. Some of these meetings were proactively sought by staff and others were in response to the letters and emails sent out.

2.1 *Responses in brief*

165 online survey responses were received. Staff received four direct emails; spoke to over 90 people across the four drop-in sessions; and 137 comments were made on the Precinct Plan Facebook posts.

In addition to general public feedback, Precinct Planning staff held meetings or workshops with the following groups:

- Members of the Youth Advisory Group and additional youth (there was an open invitation to join)
- Members of the Positive Aging Advisory Group and the Disability Advisory Group
- Students from Whangārei Intermediate School
- Whangārei Multi Ethnic Collective
- Northpower
- Kainga Ora
- Creative Northland
- Nine landowners/businessowners/Precinct stakeholders

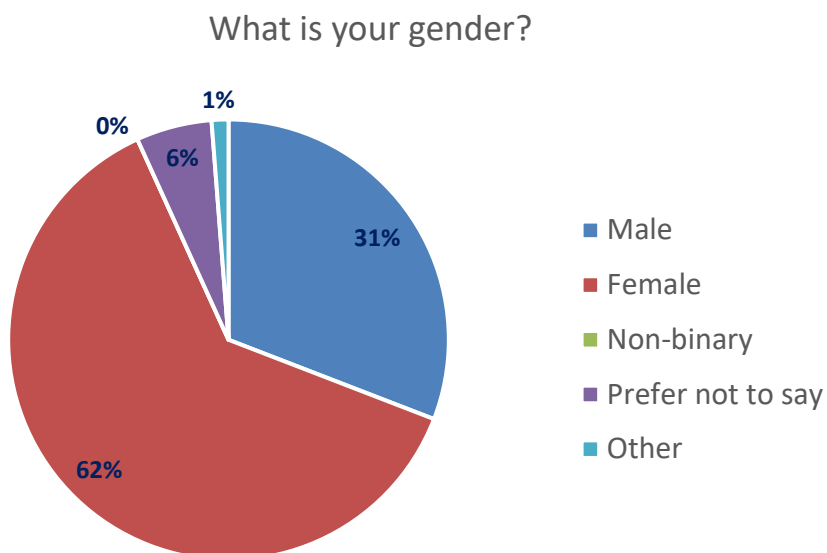
3 Summary of feedback received

3.1 Survey response demographics

The survey gave respondents the opportunity to provide basic demographic information so staff could understand the makeup of people providing feedback. The questions were not compulsory.

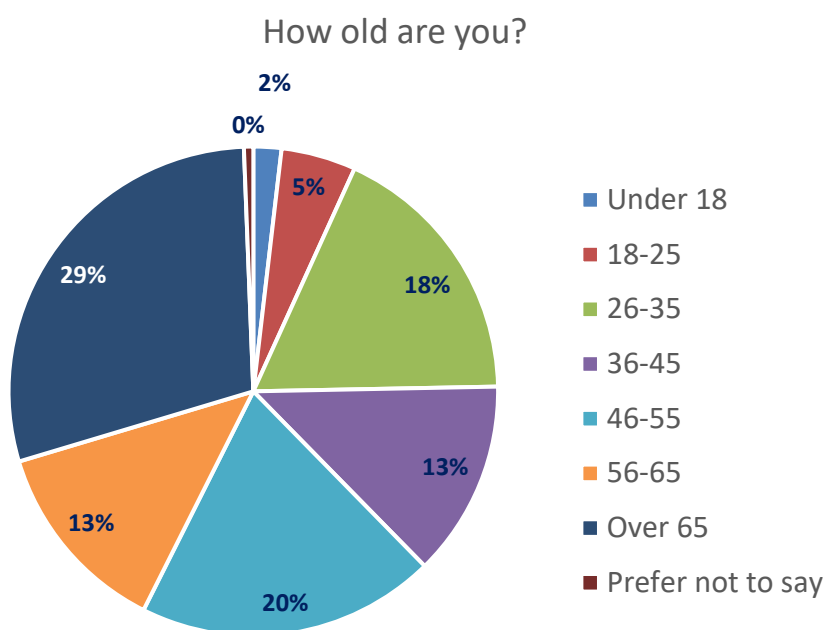
3.1.1 Gender

62% of survey respondents were females and 31% were male.



3.1.2 Age

The survey was completed by a range of age groups. The least represented age groups were 25 and under (7%), while 42% were over 56. Workshops with the Youth Advisory Group and

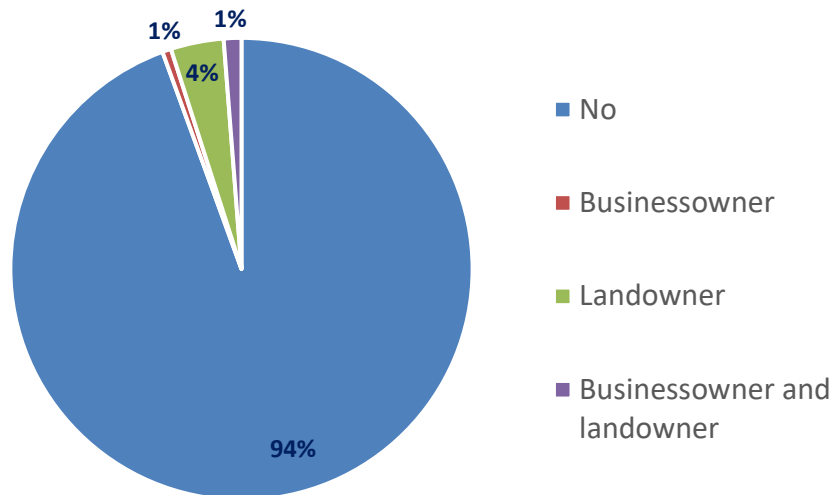


Whangārei Intermediate School were set up by staff to ensure that a youth voice was brought into the process.

3.1.3 Landownership status

The majority of respondents were not business or landowners within the Precinct (94%). 4% of submitters stated they owned land within the Precinct.

Do you own land and/or a business within the Knowledge Precinct area?

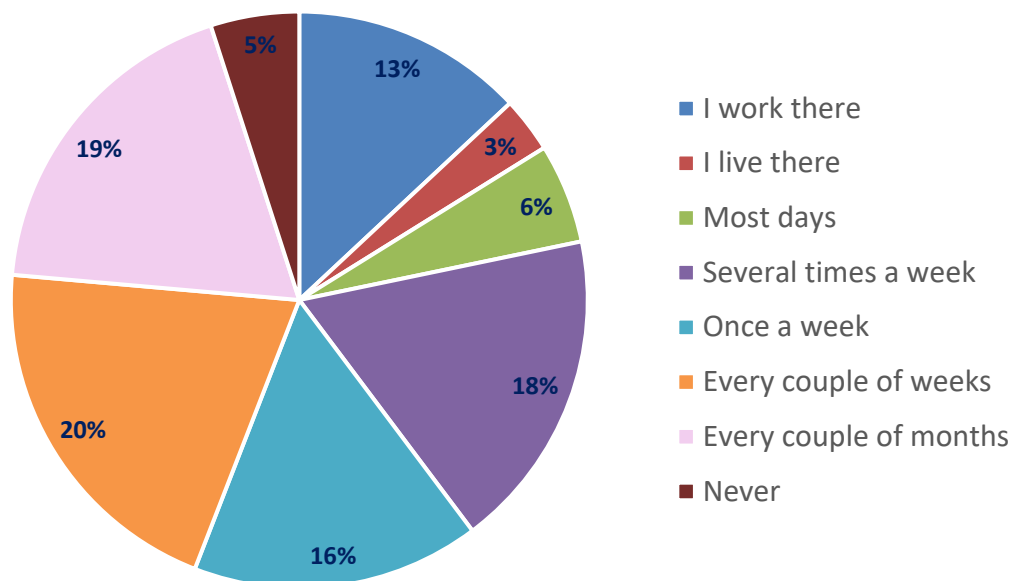


3.2 Current uses of the Precinct area

The first part of the survey asked people how they currently use the Knowledge Precinct area, what they liked about it and what improvements they would like to see.

56% of respondents stated that they visited the Knowledge Precinct area at least once a week, including 13% who work there and 3% who live there. 24% of respondents said they never go to the Knowledge Precinct area or only every few months. Of the people who provided insight into why that was, the most frequently mentioned reasons were that they simply didn't have any reason to go there; they found the level of traffic and parking scarcity off-putting; or they didn't feel drawn to the area because it wasn't lively or interesting.

How often do you go to the Knowledge Precinct area?



The table below lists the top 10 places within the Precinct that were mentioned by submitters in response to the question:

If you do go to the Knowledge Precinct area, what specific facilities / places do you or your family use / visit?

Place or space within the Precinct	Mentions
Library	113
Forum North	49
Cafler Park	40
Te Iwitahi civic building	34
Carpark	33
Healthcare services	27
Old Library (arts and music space)	25
Botanica	17
Food and beverage	15
Shared paths	13

Other spaces mentioned included the Whangārei Growers Market, shops, local businesses and YouthSpace.

3.3 Key themes from the survey feedback

The responses to the following questions have been combined and analysed by theme, rather than individually:

- If there is a particular reason why you avoid the Knowledge Precinct area (or a place within it), feel free to share why that is.
- What do you like about this area?
- What facilities or spaces in this area could be improved and why?
- Do you have any comments to add?

The key themes identified were:

- Cafler Park
- Forum North
- Parking and accessibility
- Safety
- Whangārei Central Library
- The Old Library
- Urban design and landscaping

Analysis has been undertaken by theme because this part of the survey comprised open questions with free text responses, and responses did not relate to one particular question.

For each theme, responses were placed into three feedback categories; positive feedback, concerns/negative feedback and recommendations.

3.3.1 Cafler Park

49 comments specifically mentioned Cafler Park and/or spaces within it such as the Rose Gardens and the Waiarohia River.

Support

“Cafler Park is a great central city park, especially with the new landscaping around Lovers Lane.”

20 respondents specifically mentioned Cafler Park as a space they like within the Precinct. Of those who gave further detail on what they liked about it, people specifically mentioned the park being a great urban park, the recent improvements (the new play area, bridge and paths), the Love It Here Festival, and the seating options.

Concerns

“Cafler Park does not feel like a safe place to me.”

Nine respondents specifically mentioned not feeling safe in Cafler Park, particularly in the evening and at night.

Recommendations

“The park needs to be celebrated and opened up with better connections to Rust Ave and Water Street and the Avenues (like what Lovers Lane has done) so it is more visible...”

17 responses included recommended improvements specific to Cafler Park. The most frequent recommendation was to improve connections to surrounding streets and the Forum North site. Improved security measures, more picnic facilities, more play equipment and widening footpaths were also suggestions.

3.3.2 Forum North

36 comments specifically discussed Forum North. This section discusses feedback on Forum North as it is now. For discussions on the feedback received regarding a potential new theatre, or other ideas to replace Forum North, see section 3.4 of this report.

Support

“The new and old libraries...Forum North...Some of these buildings are starting to foster decent public space...”

Forum North is generally well used by the community, being the second most frequently mentioned place people stated they visited within the Precinct (see section 3.2).

Concerns

“Sad to see Forum North closed most days unless there is a specific event showing.”

Respondents who commented on Forum North expressed concern or sadness that the building was falling into disrepair and was no longer an open, inviting space given it is closed a lot of the time. Some felt that its rundown state and low use made the area feel dull and quiet.

Recommendations

“Forum North is such a great venue for community events that it should be made more affordable for small groups to use.”

Eight respondents commented on wanting to see more community events at Forum North, particularly to help liven the space up. Several commenters felt that Forum North was prohibitively expensive for local groups to rent and suggested lowering costs. As discussed in section 3.3.1 above, several respondents suggested improving the Forum North's visual and physical connections to Cafler Park in the future.

3.3.3 Parking and accessibility

69 comments mentioned parking and accessibility within and around the Knowledge Precinct area.

Support

“The carparking is great, it's very uncommon that you find that much carparking in the city centre that's affordable and accessible.”

Key parking and accessibility features of the Precinct that respondents said they liked were the availability of carparking and the Precinct being in close proximity to many useful activities. Nine people also commented that they liked that there were walking and recreation areas away from cars and the access to the shared paths.

Concerns

“Parking can be difficult, particularly when you have little kids and need to go to the library.”

10 people mentioned that it was often difficult to find a carpark. Other frequently made comments were that the carpark was not user-friendly/well-designed and that it was unpleasant being around heavy traffic (particularly along Rust Avenue and Bank Street). Several people said that it was not an easy or safe place to navigate as a pedestrian or cyclist.

Recommendations

“[We need] multi story carpark building to reduce the need for sprawling carparks and easy cycle links.”

The most frequently stated recommendation was to improve the design or layout of the carpark. People also said they wanted to see more parking, including disability parking spaces. With regards to cycling and walking, several respondents wanted to see more shared paths and safer connections to other parts of the city. Several people wanted to see the parking area reduced and used as public space or a public transport hub.

3.3.4 Safety

Issues around safety appeared 42 times across the survey responses. Safety issues expressed generally fell into two categories; safety in terms of crime and a fear of unpleasant or threatening behaviour from members of the public; or in terms of safety around vehicles.

Support

“The new work that has been done in Cafler Park behind the library and around the new Council building looks amazing and feels so much safer now.”

Nine respondents stated that they felt safe in the Knowledge Precinct area, or that recent improvements had made the area feel safer.

Concerns

“There's little thought gone into pedestrian usage and where and how one walks to places once they've stored their car....”

Places that were highlighted as feeling unsafe were Cafler Park, the carpark and the shared path. Comments primarily related specifically to being in these spaces at night.

Recommendations

“I'd love a hub for kids and parents that is safe and dry...”

The two most frequently mentioned ideas for improving safety were improving security measures in Cafler Park and providing more indoor spaces for people to hang out. Several people wished the library had longer opening hours.

3.3.5 Whangārei Central Library

35 comments specifically included comments about the Central Library.

Support

“The library has a nice feeling and it feels safe to go with my son who is 2 years old.”

The survey confirmed that the Central Library is a valuable and loved community resource. As described in section 3.2 above, it was by far the most used place within the Precinct. Some of the most common reasons why people said they loved the library were that it was great for children, it had a range of facilities, activities and resources available; and that they loved the design, layout or range of spaces.

Concerns

“Last time I used the library there were a lot of noisy children in there, we're not talking quiet whispers either, this was screeching and swearing.”

There were only four negative comments about the library, which included noise and feeling unwelcome when Covid-19 vaccine mandates were enforced.

Recommendations

“It would be good if the library was open longer hours, especially for people who work.”

As mentioned in section 3.3.4 above, several people suggested the library extends its opening hours, particularly on the weekends.

3.3.6 Old Library

15 comments mentioned the Old Library.

Support

“The old library is a fantastic hub for the arts.”

The Old Library was also considered to be a valuable community asset. Respondents specifically commented on the architecture of the building and said that it was a great community arts facility.

Recommendations

“The individual lesson rooms used for music instruction are damp and poorly lit, creating an uninspiring and potentially unhealthy environment.”

The most frequent recommendation was the need for interior refurbishment. Specific comments were made about the state of the carpet and the need for a more purpose-built performance space.

3.3.7 Urban design and landscaping

This section discusses feedback on urban design and landscaping. It refers to public space more generally than these previous sections which focused on specific public spaces. 38 comments were specifically made about urban design and landscaping matters.

Support

“The “makeover” Lovers Lane bridge etc has been stunning and really improved the area.”

The landscaping around Te Iwitahi and Lovers Lane was mentioned 11 times by respondents as having contributed positively to the area. People also appreciated the sense of openness, the green spaces, its cleanliness and connections to other parts of the city centre.

Recommendations

“[Make the area] more user friendly for people not in cars. Not sure how the nature/green space area could be expanded... maybe inspiration from some other countries like Singapore who are limited on space but have maximized their green areas...”

The most frequently mentioned idea relating to urban design and landscaping was improving pedestrian thoroughfares throughout the Precinct. Several people mentioned wanting more greenery on the streets and expanding existing green areas.

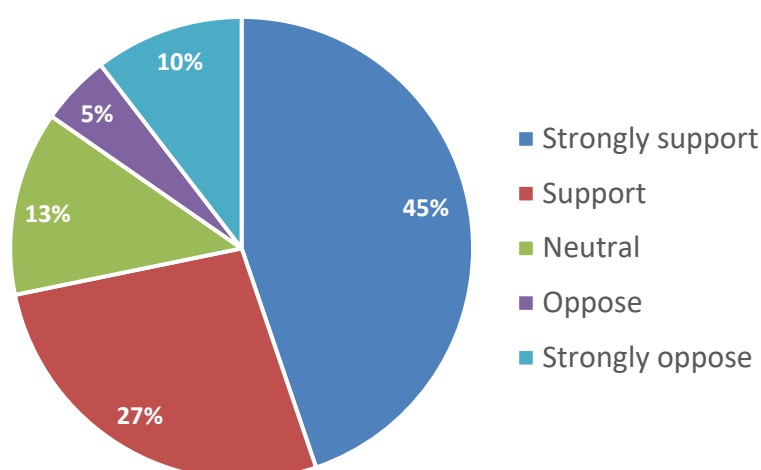
3.4 Support for the Knowledge Precinct Plan

The second part of the survey asked respondents about their thoughts on two key potential outcomes of the Knowledge Precinct Plan; a new lyric theatre and a tertiary education hub.

3.4.1 A new lyric theatre

72% of respondents either strongly supported or supported a new, larger theatre for Whangārei. 15% either opposed or strongly opposed.

How strongly do you support a new, larger theatre for Whangārei?



Support

“A new larger theatre is well overdue and Whangārei misses out on too many shows/performances because of this. If we want to attract and retain young people, professionals and people moving from larger cities, we need to be able to provide cultural experiences.”

There were 32 comments specifically in support of a new larger theatre for Whangārei. The most frequently mentioned reason was because the city wants to attract a broader range of performance and arts events. Several people mentioned the benefits it would provide future generations and the community in general.

Concerns

“Use facilities already available, don't build it bigger when there isn't the infrastructure to support it.”

Three comments expressed concerns about a new theatre (note that concerns about costs and impacts on ratepayers are addressed separately in section 3.4.3). Two people felt that a new theatre was not needed and one was concerned about parking and traffic issues that would result from a new theatre.

Recommendations

“A larger theatre would be great, but would be much more suitable in a prime waterfront location as opposed to the “knowledge precinct”.”

14 comments included suggestions for a new theatre facility. These included the need to provide more parking; ensuring there are smaller performance spaces as well as the new large one; and locating a new theatre at the waterfront instead of in the Knowledge Precinct.

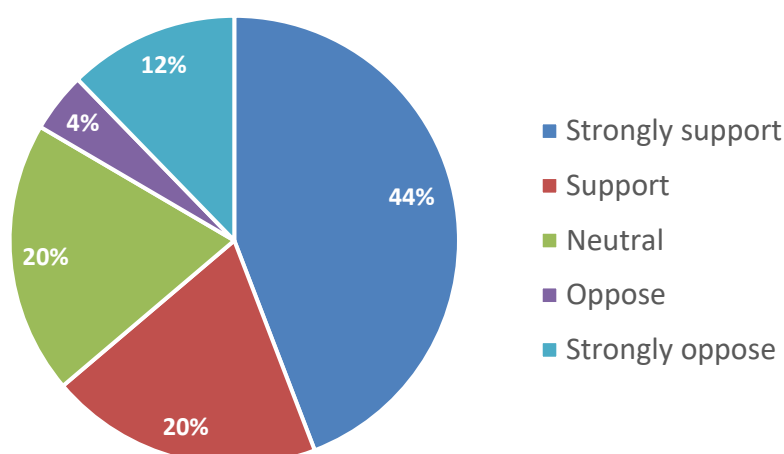
Several respondents felt that there was insufficient detail surrounding the proposed new theatre and asked specific questions in their responses. Questions included the following:

- How would a new theatre relate to/impact other theatres in Whangārei?
- Is there data to show that the current theatre is unsuitable?
- Is this as well as Forum North or instead of?

3.4.2 A tertiary education hub

64% of respondents either strongly supported or supported the establishment of a tertiary education hub in the city centre. 16% either opposed or strongly opposed.

How strongly do you support the establishment of a tertiary education hub in the city centre?



Support

“I believe a great tertiary education provider... could attract/keep great young people to and in this town which could hugely improve the social environment.”

There were 58 comments that included reasons why respondents liked the idea of a tertiary education hub. The most frequent reasons given were that it would revitalise the city centre, that it would give people the option to stay here rather than leave for education, and that it would benefit future generations/attract young people.

Concerns

“...tertiary students are better off when the education and residential facilities are developed on spacious land with pocket parks and leisure activity areas rather than try to [cram] buildings onto limited available land.”

There were 25 comments expressing concerns about the tertiary hub (note that concerns about costs and impacts on ratepayers are addressed separately in section 3.4.3). The most frequently mentioned concerns were that there would be carparking/traffic issues; that Whangārei already has a tertiary campus and doesn't need another one; and that this isn't a suitable location for a campus. Many of the concerns raised reflected the lack of detail provided within the survey, rather than people necessarily opposing the idea itself. For example, several people commented that a tertiary hub shouldn't be Council's responsibility.

Recommendations

“[I] would like somewhere that offers more advanced education options. At the moment we can only get level 6 qualifications and anything that is more "recognised" requires long term study outside of Whangārei for an extended period of time.”

Respondents had many (29) suggestions on what could make a tertiary hub thrive. The most frequently mentioned ideas were to move Northtec into the Precinct, to make sure it includes arts education and exhibition spaces; to ensure the site is still publicly accessible and to ensure the Precinct includes student accommodation. There were many suggestions of what courses to include, such as architecture, engineering and business.

Several respondents felt that there was insufficient detail surrounding the proposed tertiary education hub and asked specific questions in their responses. Questions included the following:

- How would this interact with existing tertiary facilities around the city?
- How would it work if different tertiary providers were competing against one another?
- How would young people who need additional support services be provided for?

3.4.3 Costs and other concerns

“There should be ZERO ratepayers' dollars going into this. WDC can enable any development, but must be funded by other means and self-sustaining.”

26 respondents raised concerns about costs associated with this project. The most frequently occurring thoughts were that:

- Ratepayers should not pay for the project;
- Council money should not be spent on this work and was better spent on more pressing issues; and
- this was an unnecessary vanity project.

Other opinions included that the project seemed unnecessary and that it wasn't going to benefit enough of the community.

4 Summary of feedback outside of the survey

There were several other opportunities that the community had to communicate their ideas and thoughts with project staff outside the survey.

- Four drop-in sessions:
 - Three sessions were at the Central Library (Saturday 10 May 2025, Thursday 15 May 2025 and Thursday 22 May 2025); and
 - One session was at the Whangārei Growers Market (Saturday 17 May 2025).

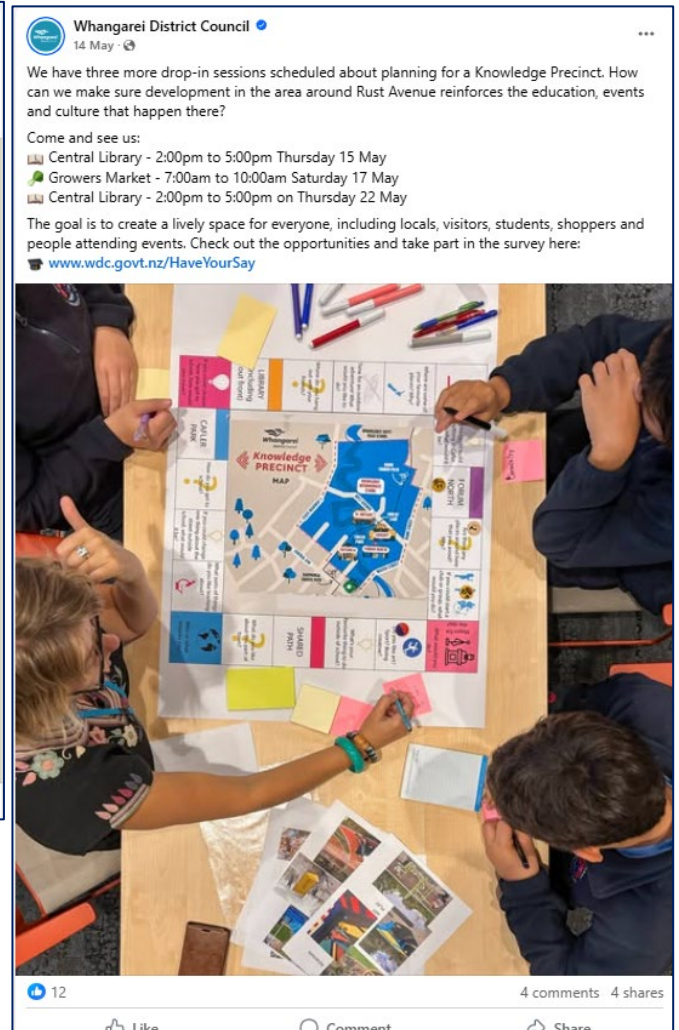
The primary purpose of these sessions was to build awareness of the Precinct Plan and to encourage people to submit survey responses, so no further analysis of these events is undertaken in this report. Staff spoke to over 90 members of the public at these events.

- The community could comment on the Facebook posts made by Council during the month of May to promote the survey. While not formally considered part of the survey feedback, staff have undertaken a review of the comments.
- A consultation email address was provided in the Knowledge Precinct pamphlet and on the website if people wanted to contact staff separately from submitting a survey.
- Staff met with:
 - The Youth Advisory Group (October 2024). An invitation to the Youth Advisory Group session was extended to all youth.
 - The Positive Aging Advisory Group and the Disability Advisory Group (March 2025).
 - A group of 19 students from Whangārei Intermediate School (May 2025). This was an interactive workshop event.
 - Nine landowners, businessowners, tenants and other project stakeholders requested meetings with project staff. These meetings were primarily for staff to inform local stakeholders about the project and give them the opportunity to share their thoughts and ask any questions. No further analysis of these meetings is undertaken in this report.
 - The Whangārei Multi Ethnic Collective. Staff spoke to the Collective in one of their regular meetings to promote the survey. This was not a workshop so no further analysis is undertaken in this report.
 - Three government agencies to discuss the project:
 - Northpower;
 - Northland Regional Council staff; and
 - Kainga Ora.

These meetings were primarily for staff to inform agencies about the project and give them the opportunity to share their thoughts and ask any questions. No further summary of these meetings is undertaken in this report.
 - Creative Northland. This meeting was primarily for staff to inform Creative Northland about the project and give them the opportunity to share their thoughts and ask any questions. No further analysis of this meeting is undertaken in this report.

4.1 Facebook comment analysis

The following three Facebook posts were made throughout the month of May to promote the Knowledge Precinct Plan survey:





In total there were 137 comments, 94 'likes', 18 heart emojis, seven angry emojis, two shocked emojis, two crying emojis and one laughing emoji. 10 comments were in support of the Precinct Plan. In terms of concerns about the Plan, 36 comments included concerns about the cost of the plan and/or the cost to ratepayers and 17 comments suggested money should be spent elsewhere. 17 comments included suggestions for the Precinct Plan. These included the importance of factoring in public transport options, bringing Northtec into the Precinct, and including affordable activities for families.

4.2 Emails

We received four emails directly into our project inbox. There were no general themes as each email addressed quite different concerns.

- One made a comment about ensuring parking provision;
- One addressed concern about costs to ratepayers;
- One addressed how the project could be inclusive of disabled persons; and
- One included a list of questions about broader impacts on the city centre and Whangārei economy.

4.3 Advisory groups

Youth Advisory Group

15 young people between the ages of 15 and 24 came along for the Youth Advisory Group session where they discussed in groups what they liked and disliked about the Knowledge Precinct area, and what they would like to see here if the area was to be transformed into a knowledge, education and arts hub.

Feedback was categorised into nine key areas. The table below outlines the ideas and concerns that came up during conversations most frequently.

		Most frequently mentioned themes
Current environment	Positive features	- Youth enjoy spending time in Cafler Park - Youth like Te Iwitahi (Civic Centre), the Central Library and the spaces around them
	Issues	- Many places feel rundown (University of Auckland site, Whangārei Intermediate and the area behind the Old Municipal building were specifically mentioned) - Many places feel unsafe (Cafler Park, shared paths, Hunt Street and Alexander Street were specifically mentioned)
Ideas for the Knowledge Precinct	Community spaces, social spaces and amenities	- Include a community centre and more spaces for clubs - Include a dedicated space for markets (including night markets) - Make improvements to Cafler Park (ideas included extra bridges, more seating and improving access to the river) - Include spaces for youth, including support and health services
	Education	- Build a proper university with a range of subject options so youth can stay in Whangārei and also attract people - Northtec should move into the Precinct
	Environment	- Clean up the Waiarohia River
	Food + beverage and entertainment	- Provide a bigger theatre and a range of performance and rehearsal spaces - Provide more food options consolidated in the same area (such as food courts)
	Housing and accommodation	- Provide student accommodation - Provide or enable more high density housing
	Transport/connections/access	- Build a passenger rail station in the Precinct - Reduce/slow traffic around key roads (e.g. State Highway 1 and Rust Avenue) - Build more carparking
	Urban design and development	- Redevelop parts of the Precinct (the Avenues, Hunt Street, YWCA site, the Old Library were specifically mentioned) - Include more shops and attractions

Positive Aging Advisory Group and Disability Advisory Group

A combined session for the Positive Aging Advisory Group and the Disability Advisory Group was held in March 2025.

The group were particularly interested in the sorts of courses that could be provided in a tertiary hub, and how great it would be to retain and attract more young people to the district. Their concerns revolved around safety and accessibility. They felt that particular places around the Precinct were unsafe, such as the shared paths; and that footpaths generally weren't well designed for people with disabilities. They expressed concerns about how there may be conflict between everyday users of the space and new users such as students, and felt it was important that disability parking spaces were included in any future development. They recommended Council

work closely with ratepayers and local businesses to ensure the needs of the whole community were met through the Precinct Plan.

4.4 Whangārei Intermediate School

Staff facilitated an activity where students answered broad questions about what they liked and disliked about the Knowledge Precinct area, and what they would like to see here if the area was transformed into a knowledge, education and arts hub.

Feedback has been categorised into six key areas, similar to the feedback from the Youth Advisory Group. The table below outlines the ideas and concerns that came up during conversations most frequently.

		Most frequently mentioned themes
Current environment	Positive features	- There are spaces to hang out with friends and/or wait for parents after school - There are trees and lots of nature
	Issues	- The shared path feels unsafe and intimidating - Youth haven't heard of Cafler Park or had never been there
Ideas for the Knowledge Precinct	Community spaces, social spaces and amenities	- More playground equipment in Cafler Park - Include sports courts (e.g. a half basketball court) - Include indoor sports facilities - Provide spaces for arts and learning events such as science fair - Provide more books for young people at the library - Provide more spaces for indoor activities/games/entertainment - Build a skatepark
	Environment	- Increase opportunities to interact with nature
	Food + beverage and entertainment	- Include more places for people to eat
	Transport/connections/access	- Design a safer pedestrian environment (e.g. have wider footpaths) - Make it easier/safer to be picked up and dropped off outside school (e.g. more path options for vehicles)

5 Next steps

The responses will help staff shape a draft Knowledge Precinct Plan, which will go out for public consultation before being finalised and adopted.

6 Appendices

6.1 Appendix 1. Knowledge Precinct Survey

Have your say on the Knowledge Precinct Plan

Survey open from Monday 5 May to 4:00pm on Friday 30 May 2025

We would like you to help us develop a Knowledge Precinct Plan for Whangārei. Centred around Rust Avenue, the Knowledge Precinct area includes Whangārei Central Library, the Old Library, Forum North, Cafler Park, Botanica and Te Iwitahi (civic centre).



The Knowledge Precinct Plan is a chance to transform this part of the city into a vibrant hub for events, culture and tertiary education opportunities for Te Tai Tokerau. Our goal is to create a lively space for locals, visitors, students, shoppers and people attending events.

Points to remember when providing feedback

- Please print clearly. The form should be easy to read and be understood and may need to be photocopied.
- All feedback is considered public under the Local Government Official Information and Meetings Act and may be published and made available to elected members and the public.
- The collection and use of personal information by Whangārei District Council is regulated by the Privacy Act 2020. www.wdc.govt.nz/Privacy
- Your feedback will not be returned to you once it is lodged with Council. Please keep a copy for your reference.

How to get this form to us

In person: By visiting Customer Services at either:

- Te Iwitahi (civic centre), 9 Rust Avenue, Whangārei
- Ruakākā Service Centre, Takutai Place, Ruakākā

By phone: Phone 09 430 4200 or 0800 932 463 and one of our friendly Customer Services staff will fill out this form for you over the phone.

By post: Knowledge Precinct Plan survey
Whangarei District Council
Private Bag 9023
Te Mai
Whangārei 0143

By email: PlanConsult@wdc.govt.nz

Online: Complete this form online: www.wdc.govt.nz/KPP

Your feedback

How you currently use the Knowledge Precinct area

1. How often do you go to the Knowledge Precinct area?

- | | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|--|
| ☐ I work there | ☐ I live there | ☐ Most days |
| ☐ Several times a week | ☐ Once a week | ☐ Every couple of weeks |
| ☐ Every couple of months | ☐ Never | |

2. If there is a particular reason why you avoid the Knowledge Precinct area (or a place within it), feel free to share why that is.

3. If you do go to the Knowledge Precinct area, what specific facilities / places do you or your family use / visit?

Think about all the places within the precinct, including schools, health and social services, businesses, public spaces, carparks, creative arts spaces and civic buildings.

4. What do you like about this area?

5. What facilities or spaces in this area could be improved and why?

The proposed Knowledge Precinct

1. How strongly do you support a new, larger theatre for Whangārei?

- ☐ Strongly support
 ☐ Support
 ☐ Neutral
☐ Oppose
 ☐ Strongly oppose

2. How strongly do you support the establishment of a tertiary education hub in the city centre?

- ☐ Strongly support
 ☐ Support
 ☐ Neutral
☐ Oppose
 ☐ Strongly oppose

3. Do you have any comments to add?

A bit about you

1. What is your gender?

- ☐ Male
 ☐ Female
 ☐ Non-binary
 ☐ Prefer not to say
☐ Other _____

2. How old are you?

- ☐ Under 18
 ☐ 18-25
 ☐ 26-35
 ☐ 36-45
☐ 46-55
 ☐ 56-65
 ☐ Over 65

3. Do you own land and / or a business within the Knowledge Precinct area?

- ☐ No
 ☐ Business owner
 ☐ Landowner

4. Would you like to be contacted in the future about the Knowledge Precinct Plan?

- ☐ Yes
 ☐ No

Name: _____

If you are filling out this survey on behalf of a group or organisation, please include their name.

Email address: _____

5.2 Operational Report – Strategy, Planning and Development – September 2025

Meeting: Strategy, Planning and Development Committee

Date of meeting: 18 September 2025

Reporting officer: Dominic Kula (General Manager – Planning and Development)
 Aaron Taikato (General Manager – Strategy and Democracy)

1 Purpose / Te Kaupapa

To update the committee on the operations of the services that the Strategy and Democracy Group, and the Planning and Development Group are responsible for.

2 Recommendation / Whakataunga

That the Strategy, Planning and Development Committee notes the Strategy and Democracy and Planning and Development Operational reports for September 2025.

3 Background / Horopaki

The purpose of the Strategy, Planning and Development Committee is to update Councillors on operational matters relating to the Strategy and Democracy and Planning and Development Groups.

4 Significance and engagement / Te Hira me te Arawhiti

The decisions or matters of this Agenda do not trigger the significance criteria outlined in Council's Significance and Engagement Policy, and the public will be informed via Agenda publication on the website.

5 Attachments / Ngā Tāpiritanga

Attachment 1 – Operational Report – Planning and Development – September 2025

Attachment 2 – Operational Report – Strategy and Democracy – September 2025

Operations Report Planning and Development

September 2025

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1. District Plan

1.1 Health and Safety

Nothing to report.

1.2 Current Priorities

The Government's "Plan Stop" has now been enacted into law limiting plan changes that can be progressed ahead of the planned replacement of the Resource Management Act (RMA). The new law allows Councils to seek an exemption for some plan change work, particularly where it aligns with the goals of the Government reform programme.

As discussed at the Council briefing on 14 August 2025, exemptions will be sought for some of the work within the current District Plan work programme over the coming months. Where exemption applications are successful, the newly elected Council will retain decision making over the progression of these plan reviews through to the notification stage.

1.2.1 Plan Changes

Table 1 below sets out the status of current plan changes and the influence (if any) of Central Government Resource Management (RM) reform on this work.

Table 1: Current Plan Change Status

Plan Change	Status	Status Update	Influence of Resource Management Reforms
PC1 – Natural Hazards	Subject to Appeals	Council staff are undertaking direct discussions with appellants in relation to six appeals. Staff filed its first report on mediation progress with the Environment Court on 30 May 2025. A second report was filed on mediation progress with the Environment Court on 5 September 2025.	The decision version of PC1 is well aligned with proposals for a new National Policy Statement on Natural Hazards (NPS-NH). This plan change is unaffected by the "Plan Stop" and can continue.
PC3 - Rosvall Sawmill Rezoning	Hearing postponed	The applicant chose to postpone the hearing that had been scheduled for 28 July 2025 to seek to address concerns raised in submissions prior to a rescheduled hearing. The rescheduled hearing is expected in the coming months.	This plan change is unaffected by the "Plan Stop" and can continue.
PC5 – 422 Marsden Point Road Rezoning	Application processing paused	The applicant has requested to place the notification on hold until mid-September due to being overseas. Preparation for notification will resume once the applicant has returned.	This plan change is unaffected by the "Plan Stop" and can continue.

1.2.2 Maintenance and Review Work

Maintenance and review work for the District Plan undertaken in July 2025 has included activities as outlined in Table 2 below. In the context of recent “Plan Stop” and other RM reform announcements Staff are considering the value of progressing this work and what the scope of this might look like. Plan review work that will align with the potential new resource management legislation can continue; however, notification of a plan change under the RMA is no longer provided for unless an exemption is either automatic or granted.

Table 2: Maintenance and Review work

Plan Review	Work undertaken in past month	Status in context of RM Reform announcements
Matters of Importance to Hapū	The team have sent out an ‘Affected Parties Engagement’ survey for hapū partners to complete. The information gathered from this survey will help Council staff to understand if hapū partners are keen to be involved in engaging with directly affected parties and at what scale engagement may need to take place. Staff are also seeking feedback from formal hapū partners to inform: • A Data Protection Protocol setting out Councils’ process for management of sensitive hapū information in accordance with Council obligations under data sovereignty agreements. • A Site Identification Sheet to be used in the mapping phase of the project. Mapping of sites and areas of significance to Māori by hapū partners (with support by Council) is set to commence during September 2025. In addition an initial discussion about the Onoke site has been undertaken with the landowner Onoke Heights Limited (OHL). Staff also attended a relationship meeting with Nga Mahinga Ngati Kahu o Torongare in August to discuss progression of this work, either through the Matters of Importance to Hapu workstream, or as a standalone matter/exemption.	Government’s “Plan Stop” requirements mean that these draft plan changes cannot proceed to notification unless the Minister grants an exemption. Staff are in the process of preparing a “Plan Stop” Exemption Application. Regardless of the success of the “Plan Stop” exemption application, it is recommended that the mapping component of this work continue as it is expected to be used to inform plan-making in the replacement RMA planning system.

Temporary Activities, Cross Boundary Matters, Contaminated Land and Minor Improvements	Documentation required to inform proposed plan changes for Temporary Activities, Cross Boundary Matters and Contaminated Land, and Minor Improvements has been completed. A report was taken to the July Strategy, Planning and Development Committee meeting to seek a decision of Council to notify the Plan Changes. However, the Committee decided that the report should lie on the table due to Government's "Plan Stop" direction.	Government's "Plan Stop" requirements mean that these draft plan changes cannot proceed to notification unless the Minister grants an exemption. Council staff are in the process of preparing a "Plan Stop" Exemption Application.
Renewable Energy Infrastructure Network Utilities	Work currently paused pending national direction being gazetted.	This work is influenced by National Direction for Renewable Energy Generation and Network Utilities which is currently under review by Government. New and amended National Direction is expected to be gazetted before the end of 2025. Government's "Plan Stop" requirements mean that these draft plan changes cannot proceed to notification unless the Minister grants an exemption. Council staff are preparing a Plan Stop Exemption Application for these plan reviews.
Ecosystems and Biodiversity Public Access	Work currently paused.	This work is influenced by the National Policy Statement for Indigenous Biodiversity which is currently being amended by Government. Government's "Plan Stop" requirements mean that these draft plan changes cannot proceed to notification unless the Minister grants an exemption. In the context of the Governments' "Plan Stop, the uncertainty around how Significant Natural Areas might fit in a replacement RMA Planning system, and the limited known issues relating to these topics of the District Plan, this work has been de-prioritised in the work programme.

1.2.3 Monitoring

Staff have commenced District Plan monitoring to ensure the plan's efficiency and effectiveness in managing land use and resources. The key monitoring topics are:

- **Zone Boundary Review**
Conducting a review of appropriateness of zone boundaries in the context of development constraints, land use trends and strategic spatial objectives.
- **Medium Density Zone – Impact Assessment**
Evaluating development trends in the Medium Density Zone to identify implementation and uptake of medium density opportunities.
- **Business Land Development Sufficiency Update**
Reviewing business land development capacity through ground-truthing development potential and suitability of assumed capacity for anticipated future business needs.
- **Net Environmental Benefit**
Reviewing the implementation of the net environmental benefit approach to ensure it is delivering good outcomes. This includes legal protection and ongoing management of significant ecological and heritage values.
- **Quarry Buffer Zones**
Assessing the alignment of mapped Buffer Areas with resource consent requirements for quarry operations. This review will identify whether the Buffer Areas are fulfilling their intended function.

The monitoring will provide an evidential foundation to inform the replacement spatial plan following the central government resource management reforms. Monitoring outputs and findings will be presented to Council in early 2026.

1.2.4 ePlan

The ePlan Enhancements Project is well underway. The first round of enhancements to functionality (to address current workarounds in the system that have the potential to result in issues with the legal version of the District Plan), were deployed successfully into production on 20 August 2025. The project is expected to be completed by the end of September 2025.

1.2.5 Process Improvement

Work has continued to improve some of our processes:

- **Business Process updates**
Staff have continued work updating our process manuals to ensure business process changes arising from the implementation of ePlan are captured. At the same time, we are checking other aspects of our business processes to ensure they continue to meet the statutory requirements of our processes.

District Plan staff are also working with Democracy to add new delegations to the delegations register to address changes to the RMA enacted in August under the RMA Amendment Bill #2 (consenting and other systems changes). This includes new delegations relating to the “Plan Stop”.

1.3 Performance Measures and Compliance

Develop, implement, and maintain a District Plan in accordance with the Resource Management Act 1991 whilst reflecting the desires of the community and issues of sustainability.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Plan changes are researched, proposed, consulted and reported on as required by Council in accordance with the relevant statutory requirements.	100%	Achieved

1.4 Current Challenges/Issues

The main challenges in the work programme of the District Plan are as outlined below.

1.4.1 Resource Management Reform

As highlighted by the recent Central Government “Plan Stop” announcement, the RM Reforms continue to have the potential to require a rescoping or reprioritising of our work programme. We will continue to actively monitor the wider RM Reform to ensure we are well placed to respond to the replacement Resource Management system once it is enacted.

1.4.2 Matters of Importance to Hapū plan reviews

Data sovereignty issues associated with the Matters of Importance to Hapū plan reviews must be well managed, along with the strategy to produce the work in a partnered and co-designed way. These plan reviews require hapū to identify and offer their knowledge into the process. This requires a level of trust around the sharing of this knowledge, and a clear and shared understanding around how this knowledge will be used.

Data Sovereignty matters are being managed through:

- the signing of data sovereignty agreement with hapū as part of contract negotiations; and
- the development of a data management protocol as part of the Project to ensure the protection of hapū data shared into this Project over the long term and in accordance with the terms of the data sovereignty agreement.

A risk register is actively reviewed by staff each month to ensure risks associated with the Matters of Importance to Hapū plan reviews are appropriately managed.

1.4.3 ePlan

The ePlan presents some challenges around the on-going maintenance of this system. Staff have developed, and are in the process of implementing, a risk management strategy for ePlan to ensure potential risks around this are mitigated. Progress toward minimising risks associated with ePlan is reviewed by Staff each month. The ePlan enhancement project which is currently underway is a key part of the risk management strategy.

1.5 Overview of Operational Activities

1.5.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

The Sites of Significance to Māori and Significant Natural Areas challenge noted above has the potential to pose a risk in this space if the work is not well managed.

1.5.2 Delegated Financial Authority Policy

Nothing to report this month.

1.5.3 Budget/ Financial

The current priorities outlined in Section 1.2 of this report are undertaken by Planning staff, with some non-planning technical expertise associated with this work being funded by the Operational District Plan budget. The Operational District Plan budget also covers the cost of notification, submission and hearing processes (e.g. commissioners and postage costs) for plan changes.

All actual and reasonable costs of processing the private plan changes (to a decision) will be on-charged to the Applicant. The cost of any Council involvement in appeals to these private plan changes (e.g. lawyer time) sit with Council.

The ePlan Enhancements project is funded from the ICT project budget.

1.6 *Legislation Changes or Updates*

Following feedback received from elected members in Briefings submissions were prepared on the National Direction package and Going for Housing Growth proposals. As previously reported, these were approved under delegation to the Strategy Planning and Development Chair and two Committee Members. Final submissions along with the letter to/response from Minister Chris Bishop in relation to the recent “Plan Stop” announcements, are provided as Attachment 1.

The RMA Amendment Bill #2 (consenting and other systems changes) which includes the “Plan Stop” direction was enacted into law in August 2025.

There were no further RM Reform announcements in August 2025 of relevance to the District Plan work programme.

1.7 *Future Planning / What’s Coming Next?*

Noting the potential impact of RM Reform on the District Plan work programme, the “Plan Stop” announcement and the election shutdown period it is expected that over the coming months the work of the District Plan team will be heavily focused on the monitoring work programme discussed in Section 1.2.3. This will also include annual monitoring to meet statutory requirements under the National Policy Statement for Urban Development.

2. District Development

2.1 Health and Safety

Nothing to report.

2.2 Current Priorities

- **Te Aho Tāhuhu | Community First**

Recent cross-organisation sector engagement meetings with members of the building and engineering community and the feedback received from a number of private sector participants have led to further, more focused meetings with individuals currently actively involved in commercial developments within the inner city area. Feedback has been generally positive but Staff have identified the need for ongoing relationship building across the organisation with the construction/development sector to ensure a genuine customer focussed response. Work will continue to see how this can best be addressed.

- **Parihaka Transmission Mast**

This project remains stalled. While there are no immediate stability concerns with the structure nor the immediately underlying ground, the access to the site and the ground stability in the near environs remain problematic. The main access road remains inaccessible to all forms of light and heavy vehicles and further geotechnical investigation is being undertaken by the Transportation team to identify whether there is a viable solution or whether an exit strategy may need to be considered. Alongside this the need for robust continuity planning by users has been signalled to lessees, with leases rolling over to a month-by-month tenure as they expire.

- **48 South Road**

Following decisions of Council in December 2024 staff have been working through consenting options for subdivision of the site. With engineering requirements and cost estimates associated with an extension now received, this project will be reported back to Council for direction on next steps.

- **Hihiaua Peninsula Consultation**

The variation to the funding agreement has been signed all parties. This variation will provide more certainty over the milestones that trigger payments and ensure better coordination between the Trust and Council during the disbursement of the final tranches of Council's funding in relation to the development of Stage Two.

An inhouse working group has been formed to engage with the Trust throughout Stage Two to ensure a strategic alignment between all parties in particular with how the public open spaces interact with those areas that may be subject to the proposed lease.

The final designs for Stage Two are expected towards the end of this year with consent and construction due to commence in 2026. Final hapū engagement continues prior to concluding lease terms with the Trust. At this stage, only technical matters remain – specifically boundary adjustments related to the lease areas and areas that will be subject to licences to occupy. The aim is to ensure, where possible, continued unrestricted public access to open spaces.

- **Okara Marina**

The Trust remains in compliance with the terms of Council's \$5m loan agreement and is meeting its monthly interest payment obligations.

Stage One (dredging and base reclamation) was funded by Council's loan and is complete. Sufficient berth licence sales have been achieved to enable the Trust to commence Stage

Two, comprising the construction of M Pier (44 berths), raising the reclamation level and installation of temporary shore facilities.

Stage Two is being financed through a combination of Trust cash reserves, trading surpluses and berth licence purchaser deposits. Concrete pontoons were fabricated off-site and have been delivered to site. The gangway abutment is complete with the gangway installed. A crane is currently on-site lifting pontoons onto the water. Piling is due to commence, in coordination with the pontoon installation. Preparations are being made for water, wastewater and electricity services to be installed.

The Trust is aiming to have the first vessels berthed in the Okara Marina during the Whangarei Maritime Festival 11-12 October 2025.

Current photos:



2.3 *Current Challenges/Issues*

No immediate challenges for staff at present other than some ongoing property legacy matters that have a continuing impact on staff capacity.

2.4 Overview of Operational Activities through to July 2025

2.4.1 Economic Development

- **Business**

The Whangārei economy remains under pressure, although the rate of decline is showing some signs of easing. Provisional Infometrics estimates show a 1.3% annual fall in economic activity for the year to June 2025, a slight improvement on the March quarter result. Weakness in construction, transport, and central government activity continues to weigh on the local economy, while the primary sector remains a key source of resilience.

Employment in the district fell 2.7% over the year to June, the fifth largest drop in the country. Losses have been concentrated in construction, administration, and retail, with some offset from gains in education and health. Unemployment is rising but remains close to the national average, a contrast to previous years when Whangārei consistently tracked higher.

Households are cautious in their spending, with card spending down 0.6% over the year. While modest, this decline highlights ongoing pressures on household budgets. Construction activity remains subdued, with residential consents falling 27% over the year and non-residential consents down 34%, their lowest level since 2020.

Feedback gathered during direct engagement with around 150 city centre businesses highlights the ongoing challenges they face. Common concerns include tough trading conditions, the impacts of anti-social behaviour, and a perception of underinvestment in the central city compared to more visible investment in the Town Basin area. The issue of anti-social behaviour was raised directly with Police Area Commander Maria Nordstrom to stress the importance of a visible police presence, as they work to stage the roll out nationally of “beat police”.

It has also been a busy time with international engagement. Whangārei hosted the Indian Consul General and a business delegation as part of the Whangārei Business Meet and Indian Food Showcase, held at NorthTec Marae alongside the Northland Indian Association. The event, which also celebrated the 79th Indian Independence Day, created valuable opportunities for connection between Northland and Indian businesses. A hugely successful event, with follow-up meetings now underway to explore potential partnerships between businesses.

The district also welcomed Mayor Yutaka Kaneko of Sano City. Sano’s Education Board continues to work closely with Whangārei Girls’ and Whangārei Boys’ High Schools on student exchanges. While here, Mayor Kaneko met with Mayor Cocurullo and visited the Hundertwasser Art Centre and Cobham Oval, reflecting Sano City’s interest in cricket as the only Japanese city with an internationally recognised ground.

Whangārei also hosted Mr Pan Jiang, Chairman of the Standing Committee of the Zhuhai Municipal People’s Congress. Zhuhai, which borders Macau, presents potential opportunities for collaboration in green energy, port development, and wider infrastructure projects.

Northland Inc. Update (as provided by Northland Inc.)

Business Enterprise and Innovation

- In the year to date, the Northland Inc Business Growth Team has engaged one-on-one with 59 Northland businesses through the regional business partnership (RBP), with 52% of them being Whangārei based.
- MBIE are hosting an RBP Service Expansion Workshop in Wellington on September 10th. The purpose is to reflect on service delivery 2025-27 and discuss service expansion options. Northland Inc will share the views of Northland RBP customers and suggest what RBP service expansions would benefit our region.

- While Callaghan Innovation will wind down by June 2026 as part of Government changes to the science system, many of its core products and services remain available. Our dedicated Navigator continues to support innovative Whangārei businesses with access to information, support, funding and grants for students and R&D.
- The Pick 2026 will be delivered from June – September 2026. The later delivery moves the final pitch evening from the middle of winter to spring. Our intention is to grow the event, ensuring ongoing delivery improvements benefiting participants and ensuring the ongoing sustainability of the event.
- The BIG team has a new Growth Advisor and Team Lead, Ben Chapman. Ben has held previous Growth Advisor roles with Business South, including the rollout of numerous funds in response to COVID19. He brings both own-business experience and roles within Tourism New Zealand, Destination Queenstown and tourism operator businesses.
- The Northland Inc BIG Team Net Promoter Score currently sits at 70 (against a KPI stated in the Northland Inc SOI of at least 50 for the year). The NPS provides a measure of how satisfied regional clients are with the business assistance and other services provided by this team. In addition to this score, we have had lots of positive verbatim feedback from customers surveyed.

Destination Management

- Northland played host to the annual Tourism Export Council of New Zealand conference in the Bay of Islands earlier this month, the first time the conference has been held in Northland in 15 years. Pre-and-post famils were offered to the 200 delegates, with famil locations including overnight stays at Lodge9 in Tutukākā.
- The RTO has represented the region at several conferences recently, including the New Zealand Cruise Association Conference in Napier, and the Regional Tourism NZ hui where the team provided feedback directly to the Tourism Minister Louise Upston on the proposed Tourism Roadmap.
- Northland Inc commissioned the publication of a Market Perceptions Report with Angus & Associates, with the 12-month data to June 2025 now available. The report surveyed New Zealand & Australian travellers in relation to their awareness, understanding and propensity to travel to Northland, along with what activities or features they associate with the region. This report will help the RTO and operators understand our domestic and Australian visitor markets more deeply, to better cater activities and marketing to their needs.
- Amy Simpkin, Destination Management Lead, spoke recently the Sustainable Business Network event in Whangārei, sharing the Responsible Tourism Programme as a regional example of sustainable activity underway in Taitokerau Northland.
- The Savour Northland programme is now live - from long, lazy lunches and unique wine tastings, to chorizo making workshops and exquisite feasts, Northland's signature food and beverage festival returns with flavour and flair. Savour Northland will run from 1–31 October and features a diverse lineup of events that hero the region's food, drink, landscapes and manaakitanga.
- The "Savour the Flavour, #NorthlandStyle" spring marketing campaign is now rolling out across radio, digital, and print media, aligning with Savour Northland as a key reason to book spring travel. Operators have been provided with templates to create their own assets and activity in alignment with the campaign, to help extend reach and impact.
- Recent media coverage has included Newsroom featuring the Northland Golfing Itineraries in their article on the rise of golf in New Zealand - How foreign investment in luxury golf courses is driving tourism income - Newsroom, the September issue of

Cuisine featuring editorial on Northland's food and beverage scene in the lead up to Savour Northland, and Meeting Newz feature on Northland including Schnappa Rock and their recent recognition as Best Destination Venue at the 2025 Hospitality NZ awards.

Tuputupu / Grow Northland

- Market Opportunities Research – draft reports received, final reports being launched mid-September. Opportunities that are being investigated are: Banana, Pineapple, Moringa, Soybean, Sunflower, Mango, Papaya, Ginger and Turmeric.
- Covered Cropping – We are looking to commission a report (through MPI funding) to provide Northland growers with a guide to protected cropping, to address weather risks and extend the growing season to produce, high value, high quality crops – e.g. novel tropical crops.

Investment & Infrastructure

- Project development – supporting a second SAF proposal to do detailed feasibility analysis
- NIWA – initial meeting with consultant leading investment memorandum development for scaling kingfish production up to 3000 tonne.

District Development Update

Accommodation Data

Accommodation data for July shows 19,900 visitors to Whangārei in July, -6% down year-on-year. However, there was a 9% increase in international visitors compared to the previous year.

Location	Nights	Jul-24	Jun-25	Jul-25
NZ	Total	2,540,100	2,174,900	2,530,200
	% YOY	33%	-8%	-2%
	Domestic	1,783,300	1,574,900	1,745,700
	% YOY	-6%	-5%	-3%
	Int.	756,800	600,000	784,500
	% YOY	-7%	-15%	2%
Northland	Total	69,500	72,200	66,500
	% YOY	-16%	12%	-4%
	Domestic	61,500	63,100	56,900
	% YOY	-13%	-2%	-7%
	Int.	8,000	9,200	9,600
	% YOY	-30%	24%	20%
Whangārei	Total	21,100	22,300	19,900
	% YOY	-16%	2%	-6%
	Domestic	18,800	20,100	17,400
	% YOY	-15%	2%	-7%
	Int.	2,300	2,200	2,500
	% YOY	-28%	5%	9%
Far North	Total	43,000	43,500	41,500
	% YOY	-16%	-1%	-3%
	Domestic	37,900	37,100	34,900
	% YOY	-13%	-6%	-8%
	Int.	5,200	6,400	6,600
	% YOY	-30%	33%	27%
Kaipara	Total	5,400	6,400	5,200
	% YOY	4%	13%	-4%
	Domestic	4,800	5,800	4,600
	% YOY	-9%	14%	-4%
	Int.	600	600	500
	% YOY	-25%	20%	-17%

From Infometrics:

- June marks the second month in a row of falling tourism arrivals. Tourism arrivals in June were down 2.5% from May, which was 0.5% down from April, all on a seasonally adjusted basis.
- Although year-end growth in arrivals is still positive, at 5.0%, arrivals have stuck at 87% of pre-pandemic levels for the past three months, which is no better than the post-COVID level of activity first seen in February 2024.
- Growth in arrivals slowed for most major markets in June. Arrivals from Canada edged up 0.1%, but arrivals from the US eased 1.6%. The US is still firmly our second largest tourism market, with US arrivals in June 50% higher than Chinese arrivals, currently our third-largest market.
- The above data reflects the information provided at the TECNZ Conference (below) and reinforces that this has been a remarkably hard year so far for the tourism industry. District Development has met with tourism, accommodation and hospitality businesses over the past month, and all have remarked on the impact of the Māori All Blacks game and how beneficial it was to have a large-scale event held during winter, their traditionally quiet period.

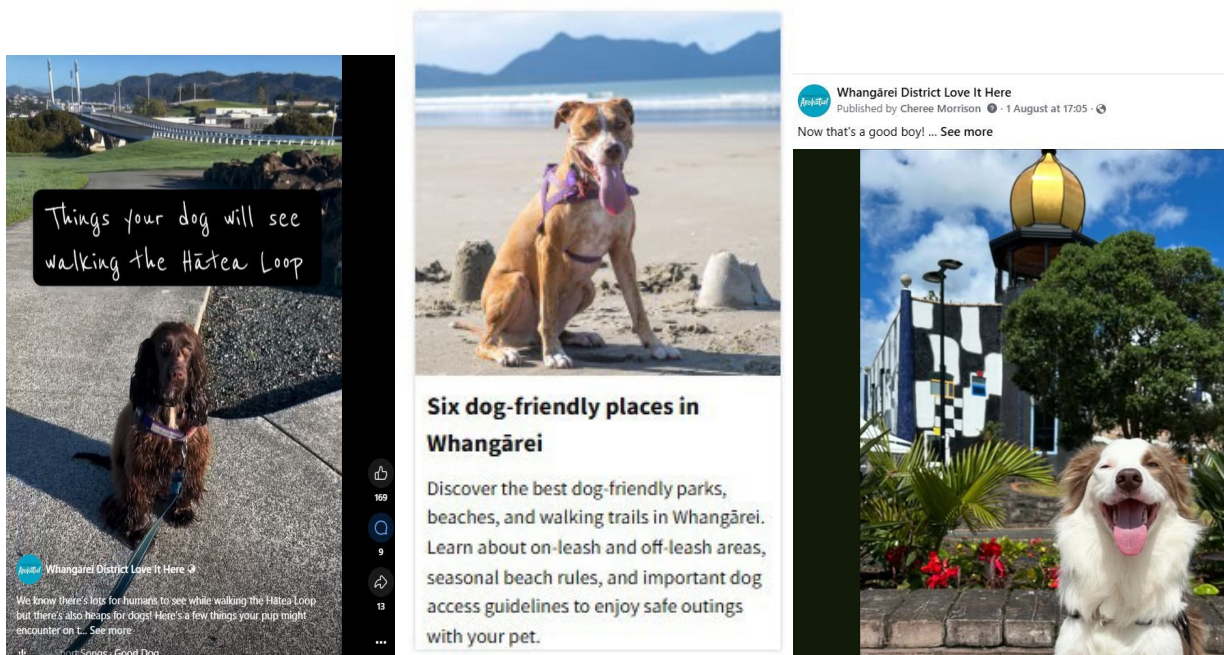
TECNZ Conference

District Development and Venues and Events represented Whangārei alongside Northland Inc at the TECNZ (Tourism Export Council NZ) conference held in the Bay of Islands. The two-day conference saw a wide variety of speakers, including Tourism New Zealand, Infometrics, several industry panel discussions and leadership experts Bruce Cotterill and Gilbert Enocka. The conference offered an opportunity to connect with the Tourism Industry, follow up relationships from TRENZ and support Northland Inc in showcasing Te Tai Tokerau.

Insights from the conference made it clear that while Tourism New Zealand are still working to their 2026 100% recovery deadline, 2025 has proven tougher than many expected and this is reflected in the subdued tourism numbers. Brad Olsen believes it now may be 2028 before we reach pre-Covid numbers based on economic activity both nationally and internationally.

Website and social media

Dogs stole the show on the website and social media. A member of the public requested a blog about dog-friendly walks, leading to the creation of 'Six dog-friendly places in Whangārei' and several dog-friendly social posts, including a video viewed 15,000 times on Facebook.



Cruise Whangārei

While Council did not attend this year's Cruise Conference in Napier, feedback from Northland Inc and Northport shares that, while work is being done by the industry, the forecast for the upcoming season (nationwide) is concerning. There is optimism that this will stabilise in 2027/2028, and Council continues to work closely with the steering committee to promote Whangārei as a destination and ensure visitor experience is exceptional. There is one ship booked for 2026, docking on 7 February.

Local Goodie

The 'Local Goodie' campaign is a celebration of Whangārei's people - the everyday heroes, the quiet helpers, the community champions. It's about recognising those who embody manaakitanga and whanaungatanga - the spirit of generosity, care, and connection that makes us proud to say we Love it Here!

2.4.2 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

There is ongoing engagement and discussions with hapū as to their role in Council commercial property. Parihaka Transmission Mast's future location requires ongoing engagement with hapū as do other proposals of both Council and third parties (i.e. Hihiaua).

2.4.3 Delegated Financial Authority Policy

Nothing to report.

2.5 Legislation Changes or Updates

Nothing to report.

2.6 Future Planning/What's Coming Next?

- **Inward Investment Pathway**

Opportunities for both domestic and international inward investment continue to arise through multiple channels, often managed in an ad-hoc manner depending on the receiving organisation's capacity. Recognising the need for a more coordinated and strategic regional approach, the Joint Regional Economic Development Committee has approved funding from the Investment and Growth Reserve to support a 0.5 FTE regional inward investment coordination role within Northland Inc for one year, as part of a proposed three-year pilot.

Council staff will work closely with this new role to ensure alignment with Whangārei-specific priorities and projects. While responsibility for hosting and meetings with delegations will remain with individual councils, the role will provide regional coordination, facilitate effective follow-up with potential investors, support identification of district-level investment opportunities, and assist in ensuring robust due diligence processes are consistently applied. The objective is to improve the quality, focus and readiness of the region's response to investor interest and enhance the chances of securing long-term, high-impact investment.

3 RMA Consents

3.1 Health and Safety

No updates.

3.2 Current Priorities

The team is continuing to manage the processing of resource consent applications, post approval applications and the monitoring of approved consents to meet the performance measure targets in the Long-Term Plan and Annual Plan, as detailed below.

3.3 Performance Measures and Compliance – Year to Date

Council will process resource consent and associated applications within statutory timeframes.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of non-notified resource consent applications processed within statutory timeframes.	≥95%	91% The development engineering team is currently experiencing capacity and capability challenges, which have contributed to delays in meeting statutory timeframes. In response, the RMA consents team is actively supporting the development engineering team by helping to establish a reporting system that enables weekly tracking and monitoring of timeframes.
Percentage of Section 223 and Section 224 applications [processed] for subdivision consents under the RMA within statutory timeframes.	≥95%	100%

Council will ensure compliance with land-use consents by monitoring consents issued.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of land-use consent conditions monitored.		
<i>Note: timeframes will be dependent on priorities based on potential environmental risk associated with non-compliance.</i>	100%	100%

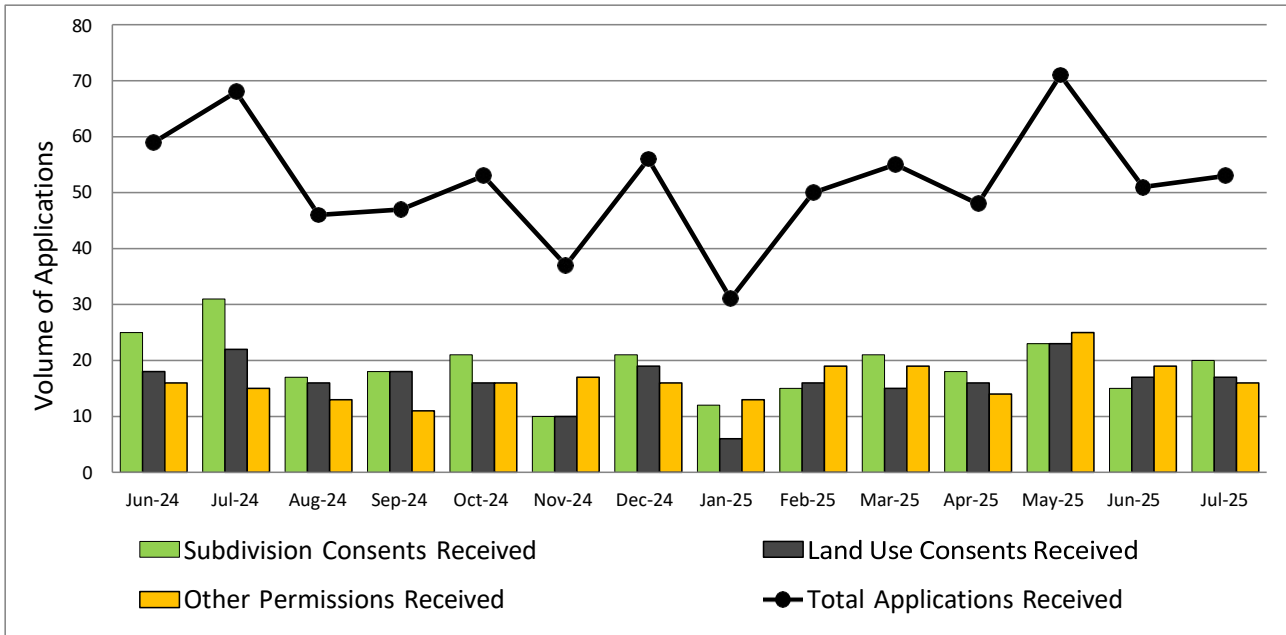
3.4 Current Challenges/Issues

We continue to work closely with the Development Engineering Team to track consent timeframes and manage capacity challenges.

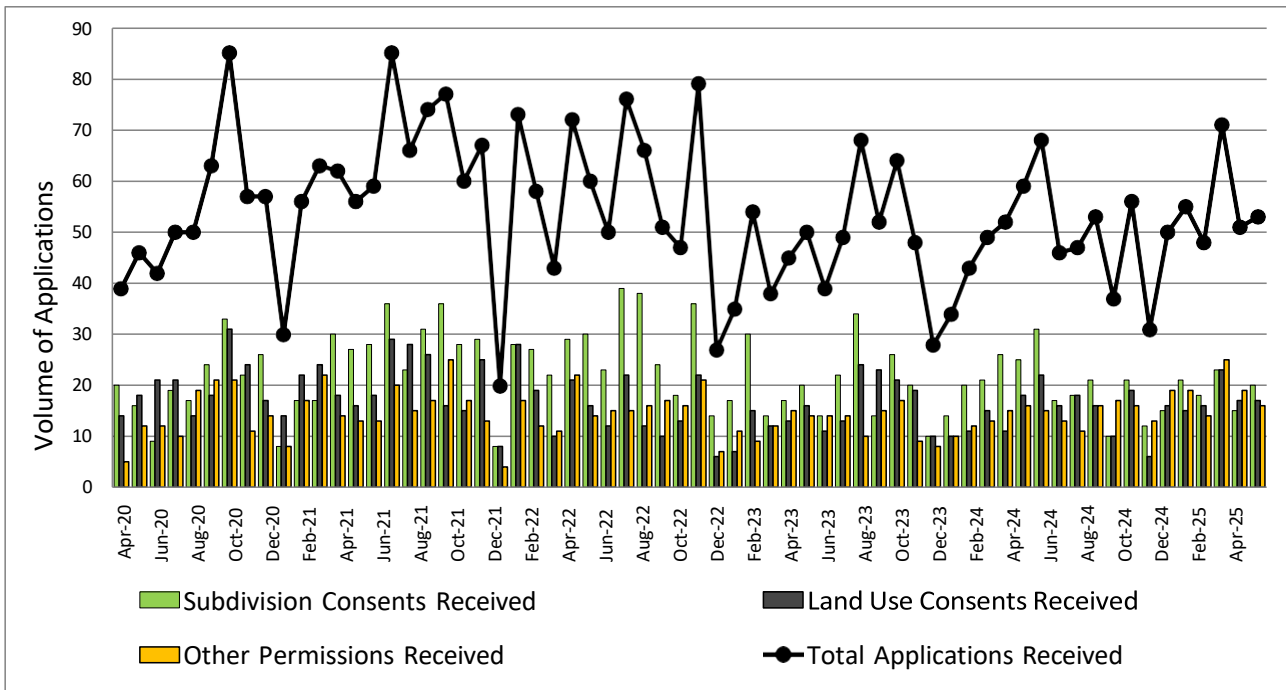
3.5 Overview of Operational Activities for July 2025

The number of resource consent applications dropped back to the level of the previous months. Post-approval applications dipped slightly.

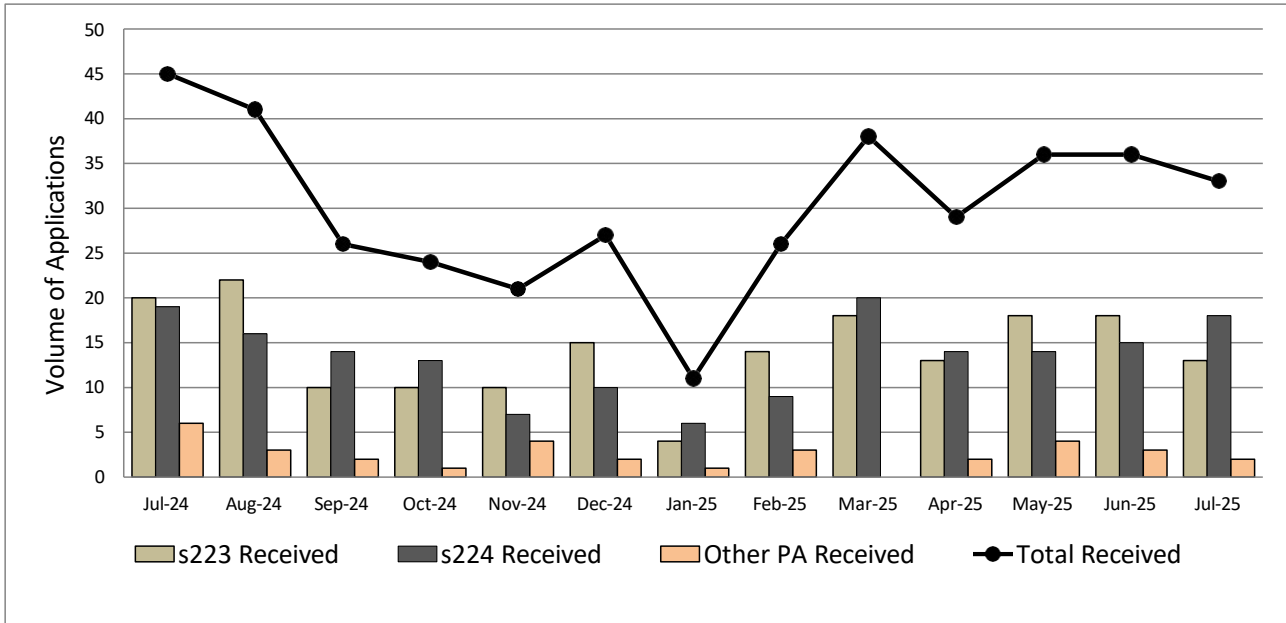
Total number of applications received over last 12 months



All applications received over the last 5 years



Number of post-approval applications received over the last 12 months



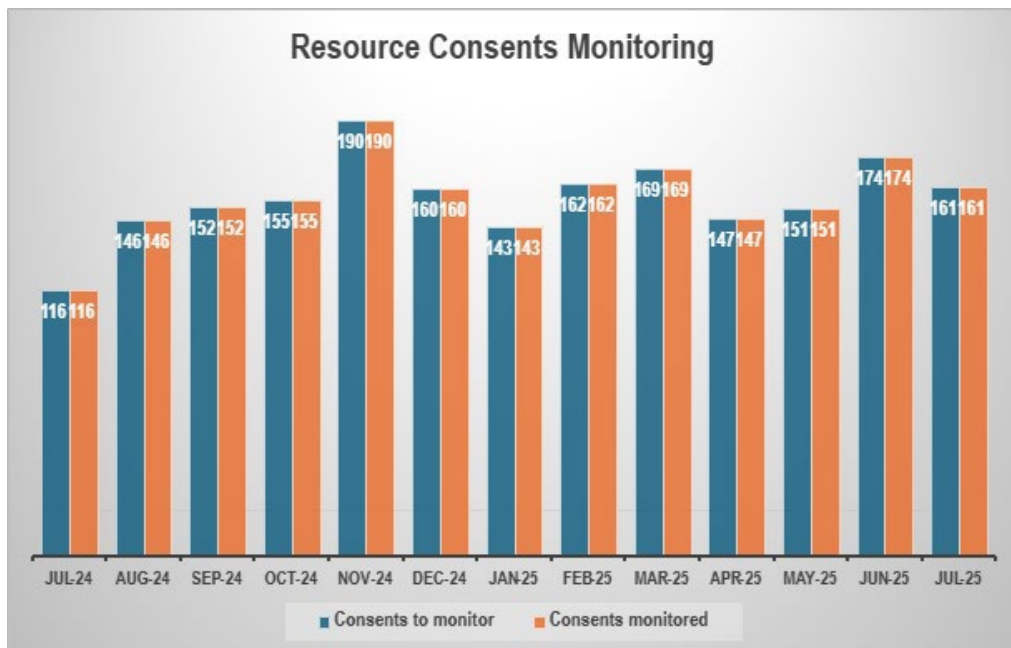
Applications of note received over the last month include:

No applications of note.

Compliance

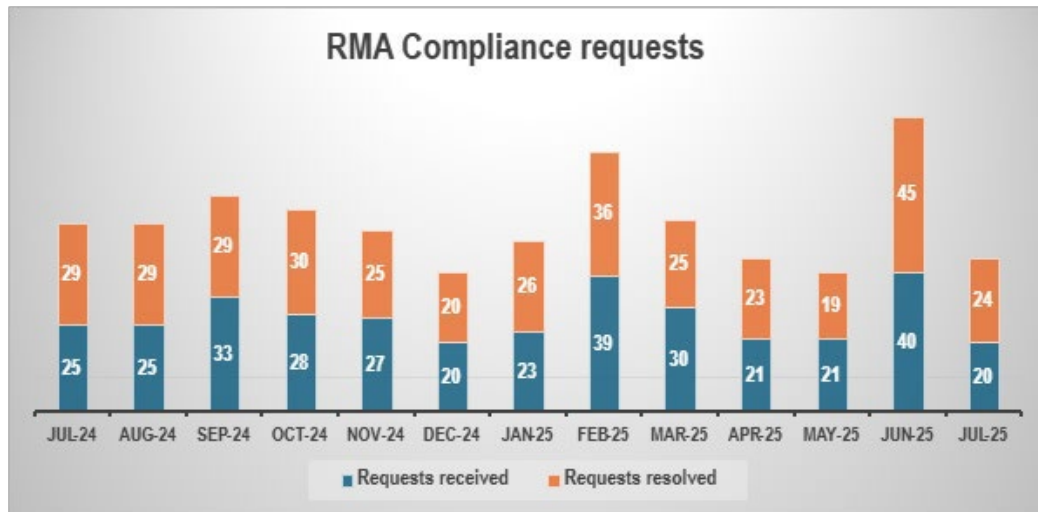
Resource Consent Monitoring

There was a 39% increase in the number of resource consents monitored compared to July 2024. This rise is primarily attributed to new consents being added to the monitoring list, along with regular follow-ups on existing consents.



Compliance Requests

Compliance requests decreased by 4% compared to the same period last year. The number of closed requests dropped by 17%, suggesting that each active compliance request is requiring more time to resolve.



3.5.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

The RMA Consents team is working on building stronger treaty partnerships with local iwi and hapū. It is noted that the resource consent process can cause friction with iwi/hapū.

3.5.2 Delegated Financial Authority Policy

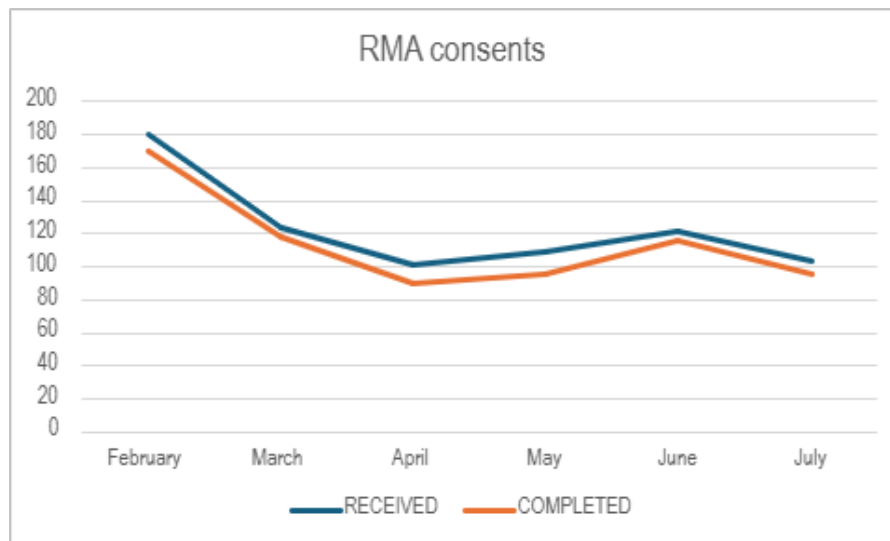
We are currently working through the contractual phase of the new RMA Commissioner panel, following the panel being approved by Council in July 2025.

3.6 Legislation Changes or Updates

The Resource Management (Consenting and Other System Changes) Amendment Act is now operative. This Act focuses on targeted changes to the existing Resource Management Act (RMA) to streamline consenting processes, particularly for infrastructure and energy projects, and to enhance the system's overall effectiveness. RMA Consents templates and processes have been updated accordingly.

3.7 Request System Update for RMA Consents

In July 2025, the RMA consents department received 103 requests, and staff closed off 96 requests.



Requests July 2025

Requests logged	103
Requests closed	96

Category Breakdown

Subdivision/land use resource consent enquiry or request for information	71
Contact us - general enquiries	9
Building consent and other enquiries	8
RMA Consents non-compliance issues	8
5District Plan and Resource Management Act issues	4

Current Status of requests as of 26 August 2025

Total	Past Deadline	Acceptance Overdue
66	34	1

4. Building Department

4.1 Health and Safety

On-going risks include vehicle safety, staff working alone, staff visiting potentially dangerous buildings/members of the public (compliance) and staff inspecting construction sites.

4.2 Current Priorities

Our biennial IANZ audit is now only 8 months away with work continuing on amending some processes (such as compliance schedules) to avoid non-compliances from the auditors.

The use of remote inspections is still a priority as it will be an invaluable tool to cope with inspection demand when the next busy period arrives. In addition to this the BCA (Accreditation of Building Consent Authorities) Regulations 2006 have now been amended to require that a minimum of 80% of inspections are carried out within the period of 3 working days after the date for inspection requested by the building owner or agent. At present the industry is slow to uptake the option of remote inspections and staff are considering options to incentivise their use.

4.3 Performance Measures and Compliance

Council will responsively and accurately manage the building consents and compliance process.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of building consents applications processed within statutory timeframes.	96%	98%
Percentage of inspections completed within two days.	≥95%	95%

98% of the consents issued in July were within the 20-working day requirement, a slight improvement from June and is a continuation of the generally positive results for 2025.

4.4 Current Challenges/Issues

Nothing to report.

4.5 Overview of Operational Activities for July 2025

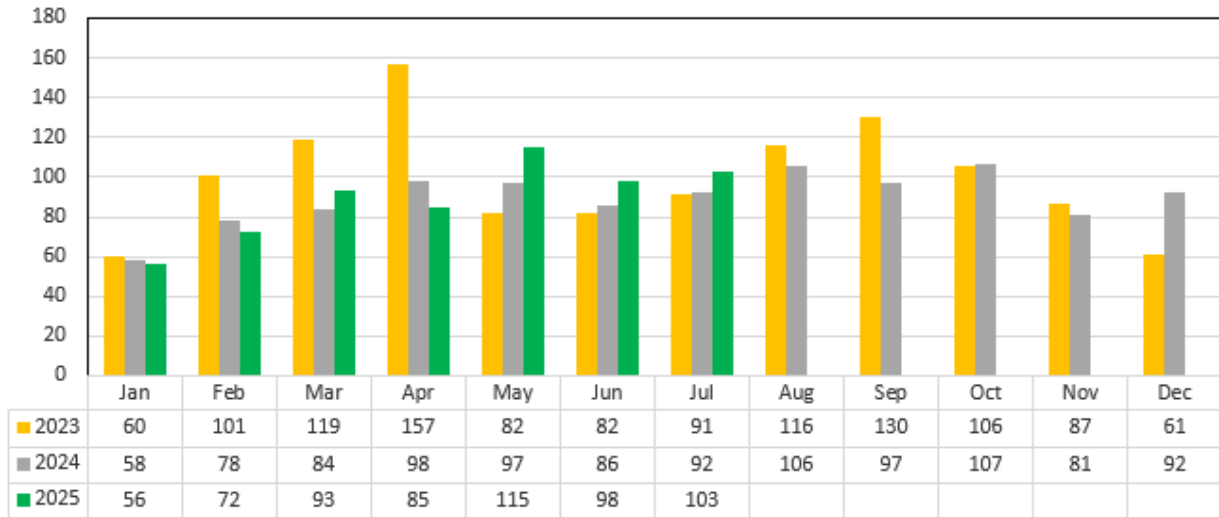
In July 103 applications were received, a slight increase from the previous month and the second highest total for the year. The last 3 months have shown increases from the same months of 2023 & 2024, although the increases are modest.

A total of 120 consents were granted in July, with an average processing time of 9 working days per consent and a total customer time of 16 days. This is the highest number of consents along with the lowest average processing times for the year.

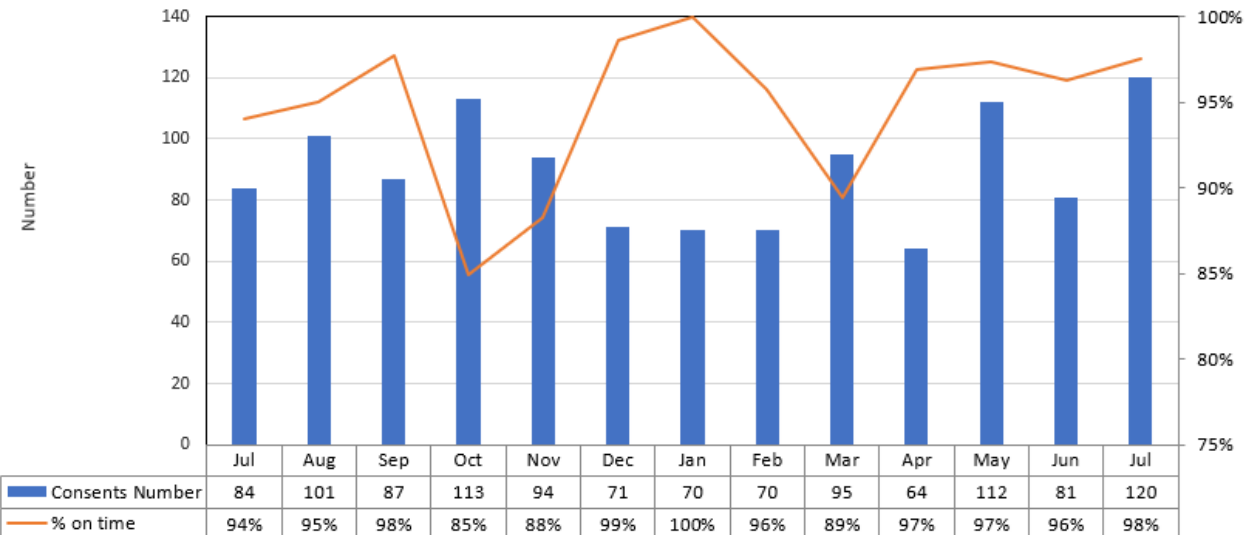
490 inspections were conducted in July, a slight increase from June but still reflects an overall drop in construction activity.

132 LIM applications were received (compared with 125 last month) with 132 issued in an average of 4 days. 24 PIMs were issued, at an average of 6 days to process. 5 PCS (Potentially Contaminated Site) report requests were received and 7 were issued, with an average of 13 working days to process. The Property Assessment Team have been working with NRC and with other WDC departments to prepare for the new LIM regulations which are effective from 17 October this year.

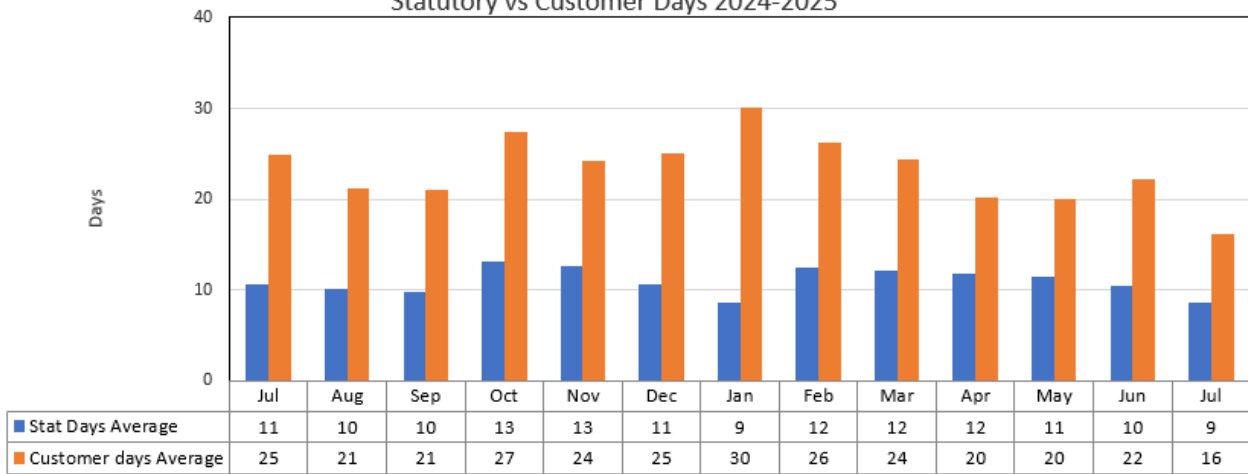
Current 3 year view of Applications Received



Number of Consents Issued and 20 day time frame performance 2024 - 2025



Statutory vs Customer Days 2024-2025



4.5.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

The activities of the building department are not considered to be a risk to the Tiriti relationship.

4.5.2 Delegated Financial Authority Policy

No new contracts were let during July.

4.6 Legislation Changes or Updates

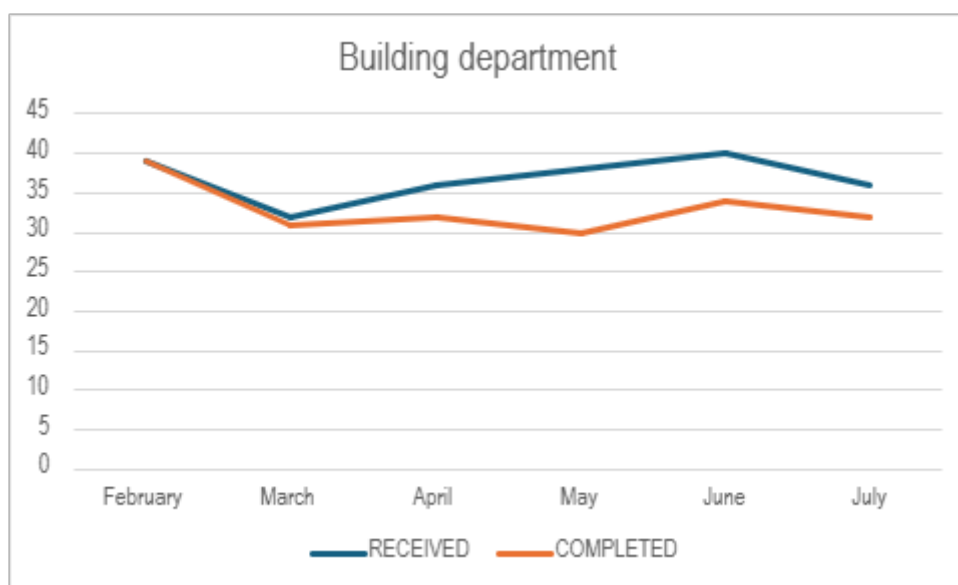
The government continues to progress its goal of reforming the building regulatory system. A draft Bill is currently being prepared which will allow voluntary consolidation of BCAs and address the issue of liability, with changes from “joint and several” to “proportionate liability”. It is proposed that this Bill will be introduced to parliament early in 2026, so may not be in place prior to the general election next year.

4.7 Future Planning / What’s Coming Next?

Currently, we are in a waiting period as there are no open consultations. Following the announcements in relation to voluntary consolidation of BCAs it is unclear whether formal consultation will now occur in relation to BCA reform.

4.8 Request system update for Building Control

In July 2025, the building department received 36 requests, and staff closed off 32 requests.



Requests July 2025

Requests logged	36
Requests closed	32

Category Breakdown

Unauthorised stormwater discharge	9
Building or development issues	8
Contact us - general enquiries	4
Building consent enquiries	4
Dangerous or unsanitary health issues	3
Alcohol licensing building code review	2

Current Status of requests as of 26 August 2025

Total	Past Deadline	Acceptance Overdue
20	3	1

5. Health & Bylaws

5.1 Health and Safety

Nothing to report and no additions to the organisational risk register this month.

However, in general, our Regulatory Services contractor Armourguard and their teams continue to face potential risks to their health and safety related to vehicle safety, staff working alone, and when interacting with aggressive members of the public through their compliance roles.

5.2 Current Priorities

With the start of the new financial year, both the Environmental Health team and Regulatory Enforcement Services contractor, Armourguard, are focussing on their core functions and aiming to achieve their individual performance measures targets, as highlighted below.

In addition, work is commencing on the assessment of the performance of the regulatory services contract, and the options for delivering this service going forward. This work will be reported back to the new Council so that procurement can commence well in advance of the expiry of the contract in June 2027, should Council wish to continue with an outsourced model.

5.3 Performance Measures and Compliance

Council will ensure responses to complaints relating to parking, excessive noise, dogs, stock, and bylaws are carried out within contracted timeframes.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of complaints responded to within contracted timeframes.	≥85%	July = due to technical / system issues no July 2025 result is as yet available for this measure These are matters are being worked through, a verbal update can be provided on the day. Year to date average = n/a

Council will protect and promote public health by monitoring those premises, which under the Health Act 1956 require annual registration and inspection.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of Health Act registered premises inspected annually.	100%	Annual measure, result only available at the end of the current financial year

Council will promote food safety by registering and verifying those food businesses which the Food Act 2014 specifies that local authorities can register and verify.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of food businesses verified within timeframes as specified by the Food Act 2014.	100%	Annual measure, result only available at the end of the current financial year

Council will aim to reduce alcohol-related harm by annually inspecting alcohol licensed premises to ensure compliance with the Sale and Supply of Alcohol Act 2012 and licensing conditions in general.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Percentage of alcohol licensed premises inspected annually.	100%	Annual measure, result only available at the end of the current financial year

5.4 Current Challenges / Issues

There are no current challenges or issues facing the department or its teams.

5.5 Overview of Operational Activities for July 2025

Business as usual, nothing specific to report.

5.5.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

The activities of the Health & Bylaws department are not considered to be a risk to the Tiriti relationship.

5.5.2 Delegated Financial Authority Policy

During July and effective for the period 1 July 2025 to 14 January 2030, a new contract to directly (re)appoint Council's current District Licensing Committee (DLC) Chairperson, Murray Clearwater was signed under the delegation of the General Manager Planning and Development. That followed Council's Chief Executive earlier signing off on a Variation to Council's Procurement Policy for "Seeking 3 or more Quotations for work between \$100k - \$250k" and to directly (re)appoint the existing DLC Chairperson to that role.

The contract now provides for a 'retention allowance', on top of the remuneration set during 2012 under the Sale and Supply of Alcohol Act 2012, in recognition of the fact that DLC remuneration rates under the Act have not increased for close to 13 years. In line with other Councils (notably Wellington) we now pay our DLC Chairperson an hourly rate similar to that of RMA Hearing Commissioners. This was considered necessary in order to retain existing/experienced DLC Commissioners / Chair, and to attract suitably qualified individuals in future. Sufficient budget exists within the Alcohol Licensing cost centre to cover this increase in remuneration rates / cost, with the service centre largely being self-funding through "User Fees".

5.6 Legislation Changes or Updates

On 20 August 2025, the Resource Management (Consenting and Other System Changes) Amendment Act 2025 was passed by Parliament. As a result, there have been several changes to various sections of the Resource Management Act 1991. Of note to us and our Regulatory Services contractor, Armourguard is in relation to Section 327, pertaining to Excessive Noise Directions. Previously an Excessive Noise Direction required the occupier of the address to where the Excessive Noise Direction was issued to reduce noise for up to 72 hours. Due to this new amendment the requirement to reduce noise has now been extended to 8 days. This will greatly assist Council in better managing on-going or repeat noise/makers and the necessary changes to documentation (infringement notices etc.) are underway.

5.7 Future Planning / What's Coming Next?

Below follows a monthly update on the construction of Council's new animal shelter (dog pound).

Project	Current Stage	Estimated Construction Start Date	Estimated Completion Date	RAG Status
New Animal shelter construction	Construction	Sep-22	Oct-24	

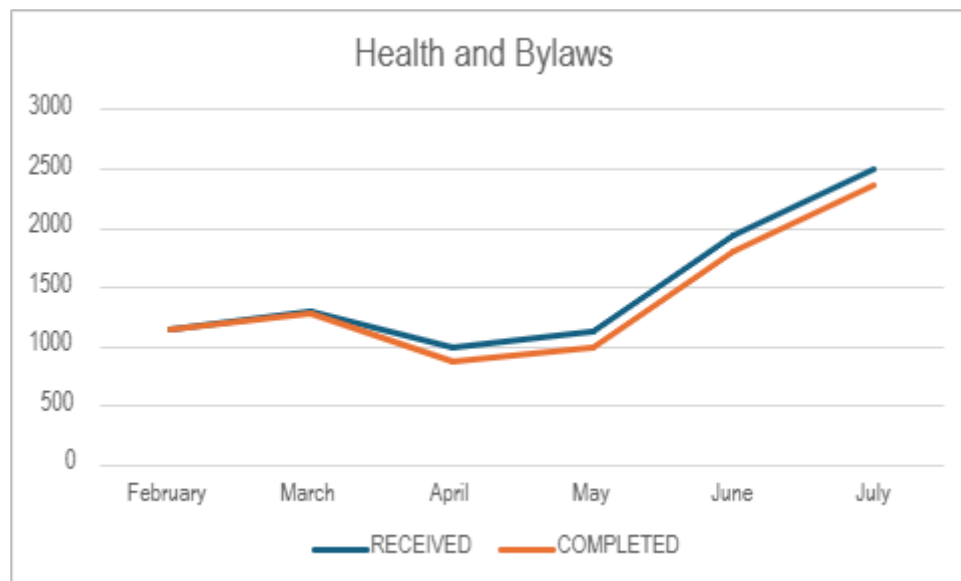
Minor snag list items are still being worked through, and construction is practically complete.

Building fit out is complete. The Armourguard Animal Management team moved in on 11 November 2024 and have settled in well. The construction contract remains within the approved contract value, and the project is expected to be delivered under the total project budget. Bank drainage installation is still required, and paperwork is being worked through for the Certificate of Compliance.

5.8 Request System Update

In July 2025, the Health and Bylaws department received 2497 requests, and our contractors and staff closed off 2369 requests.

There has been an increase in requests due to dog renewals.



Requests July 2025	
Requests logged	2497
Requests closed	2369
Category Breakdown	
Other dog issues	716
New dog registration payments and enquiries	628
Infringements disputes and enquiries	272
Residential noise	202
Animal management (internal only)	196
Parking management	106

5.8.1 Customer feedback

CC251559 - Customer just wanted to say a huge thanks for sorting the noise issue a week or so ago.

AC2529415 – 5-star rating - Very helpful CSR and Armourguard receptionist, issue resolved. Thanks

Current Status of request as of 26 August 2025

Total

767

Past Deadline

23

Acceptance Overdue

0



In reply please quote "Whangarei District Council Submission on the Updated RMA National Direction"

Or ask for Dominic Kula, General Manager – Planning and Development

25 July 2025

Ministry for the Environment
PO Box 10362
Wellington 6143

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Private Bag 9023, Te Mai,
Whangārei 0143, New Zealand
P +64 9 430 4200
E mailroom@wdc.govt.nz
www.wdc.govt.nz/ContactUs

By email: ndprogramme@mfe.govt.nz

Tēnā koe,

Submission on consultation on updating RMA national direction Packages 1 – 3

1. Introduction and background

Whangarei District Council (WDC) welcomes the opportunity to provide feedback on the proposed new and amended National Policy Statements (NPSs) and National Environmental Standards (NESs) that make up Packages 1 – 3.

In preparing the new and amended national direction instruments, WDC asks that the Minister considers the following:

2. General comments

2.1. General support for improved national direction

Existing national direction instruments under the Resource Management Act 1991 (RMA) have been a source of conflict and uncertainty, primarily because of difficulties in reconciliation between instruments, unclear direction, and no direction on certain topics. We understand that one of the objectives of the proposals is to resolve conflicts, and we welcome this intent. Similarly, we support the review and continuous improvement to increase efficiency and reduce costs. We are committed to working alongside the Ministry in shaping the direction of, and assisting in the transition to, a new system.

2.2. Reduced role for local decision-making with additional local costs and risks

The proposals represent a significant shift towards increasing centralised decision-making and reducing the role of local decision-making. We support an approach which enables a local voice and variation where appropriate. A 'one-size fits-all' approach is not always the most appropriate solution.

The proposals will ultimately result in additional work and associated costs to ratepayers associated with implementing the proposals and aligning business processes. Additionally, the national direction as proposed could create more decision-making risks for Council where it does not adequately resolve conflicts as discussed in Section 2.5 below. This could result in councils having to make difficult decisions at the consenting stage to reconcile conflicts between competing instruments. This could be exacerbated due to the recent “Plan Stop” announcements which may prevent councils from amending current RMA plans to improve consistency with the new national direction for an extended period.

If local decision making is reduced by introducing more national direction, then councils should not be burdened with unfunded mandates or additional decision-making risks.

2.3. Incorporation with wider Resource Management Reform programme

Any national direction introduced under the RMA should be considered alongside the recent Plan Stop announcements to ensure that:

- clear direction is provided on what changes can and should be made to local RMA plans ahead of the new system to give effect to the new national direction; and
- the national direction will not create new conflicts that cannot be resolved within local RMA plans due to the Plan Stop requirements; and
- the benefit of introducing the national direction can actually be realised given the fact that local RMA plans may not be able to be amended.

It is also noted that major reform programmes are more likely to succeed when they are developed cohesively and have bipartisan political support. The sector and public needs certainty that transcends political cycles. We support the Government in attempts to achieve this.

2.4. Limited engagement and consultation

Given the scale and pace of current reforms, there is a real risk that local government, the planning sector, iwi and hapū, stakeholders, and the general public will not have sufficient capacity to engage as effectively or constructively as desired.

WDC value the input of hapū and have made a commitment to working with hapū, which is evident in our Te Kārearea Strategic Partnership Committee. Due to the scale of the proposals and timeframes of consultation we have not had adequate opportunity to engage with Te Kārearea or local hapū. This could risk damaging relationships with hapū and compromise councils' and Central Government's obligations to take into account the principles of the Treaty of Waitangi (Te Tiriti o Waitangi) as part of RMA decision-making.

2.5. Resolving conflicts and balancing outcomes

Currently, some of the most challenging and time-consuming matters for assessment and decision-making relate to determining the balance between competing policy priorities. How these conflicts will be resolved is unclear within the suite of amendments, meaning they may not deliver improved efficiency or less costly consenting and decision processes.

Similarly, while we broadly support the intention to be more enabling of opportunities for development and growth (i.e. proposals such as the NESs for Papakāinga and Granny Flats), this needs to be a balanced against the protection of important resources and the environment. The current system is not effectively achieving either; however, it could be clearer how the proposals seek to better balance these outcomes.

Recommendations

- Ensure that any costs and risks that councils may be burdened with are fully understood and factored into the preparation of any national direction.
- Ensure that any new national direction provides clear conflict resolution across competing policy priorities and clearly demonstrates how economic, environmental, social, and cultural outcomes will be more efficiently and effectively achieved.

3. Comments on specific Package 1 – 3 proposals

3.1. National Policy Statement for Infrastructure

The proposed NPS-I will create a more enabling pathway for future infrastructure projects. It is unclear at this stage what the process will be for councils to manage the increased costs of additional infrastructure delivery and on-going maintenance. This is because there are companion reforms (i.e. changes to Development Contributions via a Development Levy system) happening separately.

Recommendation

- Ensure alignment between the NPS-I with other reform work, including the higher order legislation (replacement of the RMA), Package 4 (Going for housing Growth), and the Development Levy system.

3.2. National Policy Statement for Natural Hazards

WDC supports the proposal to develop national direction on natural hazards. The proposed NPS-NH would provide useful national direction to local authorities on how to assess and manage natural hazard risk. The proposed definitions, objectives, and policies are supported as they represent an appropriate approach for managing natural hazard risk. This approach aligns with Whangarei District Council's recent Plan Change 1: Natural Hazards.

Introducing a definition of "significant risk" will provide helpful clarity and consistency.

Recommendation

- Progress the development of national direction on natural hazards focused on a risk-based and proportionate approach.

3.3. National Environmental Standards for Papakāinga

WDC supports the purpose of the NES-P to better enable papakāinga development. We note that the existing papakāinga provisions in the Whangārei District Plan are broadly aligned with the NES-P, so there may be limited benefit within Whangārei specifically. However, the NES-P may enable a limited degree of additional density on smaller sites within the District and may apply to a small number of sites that the current District Plan's papakāinga provisions do not apply to, potentially creating opportunities for papakāinga development in additional locations.

Recommendation

- Progress the development of national environmental standards for papakāinga development.

3.4. National Environmental Standards for Granny Flats

WDC broadly supports the intent of the NES-GF to enable additional opportunities for minor residential units. However, we are concerned about the proposal to remove controls such as outdoor living courts, setbacks, sunlight access, and privacy. This shift could result in the removal of basic quality standards (such as minimum unit sizes, private outdoor space, or access to natural light) that play a role in supporting public health outcomes, social cohesion, and overall resident satisfaction.

The potential impacts on councils from this proposal include a greater expectation from developers and residents that councils will provide the missing amenities that are no longer required as part of building, and living in, a home. For example, if homes are built with increasingly smaller outdoor spaces, residents will have greater need for local park provision to offset the loss of personal amenity.

It is acknowledged that Government has signalled that the new system will be focused on private property rights and will have a reduced scope of what effects can be considered. However, the proposed NES-GF would be secondary legislation under the RMA. Introducing national direction that is founded on principles of a different system to the RMA could create complexity and confusion for plan users and decision makers about what effects can and cannot be considered.

Recommendation

- Progress the development of national environmental standards for minor residential units while ensuring that any changes align with the broader RM Reform programme.

3.5. Amendments to National Policy Statement for Highly Productive Land

Northland has a much higher proportion of class 3 than classes 1 or 2. Of the total area of highly productive land in the Region (classes 1-3), the proportion of class 3 land is approximately 72%. A lot of this class 3 land is highly productive and is used for horticulture - kiwifruit, avocados, etc. The class 3 land with volcanic, sand, and peat soils are all suitable for horticulture so

removing them from the NPS-HPL will make it easier for such land to be permanently lost to other development. The loss of this land would be a significant issue for Northland and therefore we oppose the removal of LUC3 from the NPS-HPL.

While addressing the housing crisis is important, there is the risk that this could come at the expense of protecting and restoring land for primary production. Since both urban development and primary production often require similar land characteristics (such as low slope, good soil conditions, and proximity to key transport routes and infrastructure) the NPS-HPL should offer clear and strong guidance to balance these competing land uses appropriately.

Removing LUC3 from the definition of highly productive land may also limit councils' ability to strategically plan and manage growth in a way that responds to local context, priorities, and infrastructure realities. Opening this land for development risks producing fragmented, sprawling, ad hoc developments that are misaligned with other outcomes such as efficient and cost-effective infrastructure delivery and urban intensification.

We support the concept that councils could identify local Special Agricultural Areas that would not otherwise be classed as highly productive land. However, it is unclear what criteria would be used to identify these areas. Basing the decision solely off national or regional significance may be vague and insufficient as it may overlook locally significant areas.

We support extending the timeframes for mapping highly productive land to 2028.

Recommendations

- Ensure amendments to remove LUC3 from the highly productive land definition align with outcomes sought through other reform proposals such as efficient and cost-effective infrastructure delivery and urban intensification.
- Provide clear guidance on the criteria used to identify Special Agricultural Areas.

Thank you again for the opportunity to comment. Please contact Dominic Kula, General Manager Planning and Development at Dominic.Kula@wdc.govt.nz if you have any questions regarding this submission.

In reply please quote 'Whangarei District Council Submission on Going for Housing Growth'
Or ask for Dominic Kula, General Manager – Planning and Development

Hon. Chris Bishop
Minister of Housing
Minister Responsible for RMA Reform

Ministry for the Environment
PO Box 10362
Wellington 6143

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Submission on Going for Housing Growth consultation

Tēnā koe Hon. Chris Bishop,

Whangarei District Council (Council) is writing to you in broad support of the Going for Housing Growth proposals, which will shape the future planning system. Council is continually encouraged to see the Government taking a strong stance on housing and promoting growth through the RM Reform work and recognise the longstanding issues of supply and affordability of housing and development.

Whangārei is an area well prepared for growth, and additional direction and tools to enable that growth are welcome. Council also notes the other changes occurring concurrently around existing planning instruments, as well as changes in building materials and processes that will further enable more—and more affordable—housing.

Whangārei has enabled development capacity and has planned and funded infrastructure. But challenges remain with coordination, affordability and delivery to achieve the growth we are working towards. Whangārei is also a District that blends urban living, lifestyle living, and rural and coastal settlements, with industrial and agricultural sectors. It is within this context that Council believes we can offer valuable perspective – different to the highly urbanised Auckland or Wellington – you have asked for via the consultation. As such, we have endeavoured to make positive recommendations to support the active and efficient implementation of the strategic direction set by Government.

Specifically, Council supports several key proposals outlined in the consultation document, including:

- The need for a planning system that enables both Central and Local Government to deliver outcomes for local communities.
- Enabling growth to support more affordable housing.
- Building upon long-term spatial planning processes and adopting a long-term view in partnership with Government.
- Standardisation of planning zones, rules, and standards.

Further details are provided in the submission attached.

Council welcomes further opportunities to engage with the Ministry on these proposals and our recommendations, including the potential for workshops between the Ministry officials and our technical staff.

Yours faithfully,

A stylized, dark ink signature of Vince Cocurullo.

His Worship the Mayor

A stylized, dark ink signature of Ken Couper.

Clr Ken Couper
Strategy, Planning and
Democracy Committee Chair

A stylized, dark ink signature of Gavin Benney.

Clr Gavin Benney
Community Committee Chair

Whangarei District Council submission on Going for Housing Growth consultation

1. Introduction

Whangarei District Council (Council) welcomes the opportunity to provide feedback on the Going for Housing Growth proposals, which will shape the future planning system.

Whangārei – a city and district with significant potential for growth – offers a valuable perspective shaped by its unique blend of urban areas, lifestyle living, and rural and industrial productivity, significantly different from the highly urbanised areas of Auckland or Wellington. Whangārei has sufficient plan-enabled capacity and a strong pipeline of infrastructure delivery. However, challenges remain in the uptake and pace of development, and in achieving a balanced integration of urban activities with the rural and coastal lifestyle aspirations of our communities.

With these challenges in mind, Council supports the Government's strong commitment to increasing housing supply and promoting growth. We appreciate the efforts to present new solutions to longstanding problems around the supply, quality and affordability of housing and development.

Council supports several key proposals outlined in the consultation document, including:

- The need for a planning system that enables both Central and Local Government to deliver outcomes tailored to local communities.
- Enabling growth to support more affordable housing.
- Building upon long-term spatial planning processes and adopting a long-term view.
- Standardisation of planning zones, rules and standards.

2. Feedback specific to the proposals

2.1. Spatial planning

Council agrees with Cabinet that spatial planning is a core tool to include in the new resource management system. It is essential for achieving positive outcomes through long-term planning and alignment of infrastructure, land use and investment decisions. Council considers that full integration requires reform beyond the RMA, including spatial planning within other legislation.

Council supports the intent to build upon and learn from current practice relating to Future Development Strategies (FDS). The Whangārei FDS adopted in May 2025 by both the Northland Regional Council and Whangarei District Council, reflects over two years of extensive collaboration and knowledge-building across the district and region. As formative documents, the FDS and its Implementation Plan should be given the opportunity to mature and embed effectively into Council processes and decision-making. For example, Council has been actively engaging with KiwiRail on various improvements to passenger and freight services that could unlock new business opportunities and expand transport options for our communities. Council would prefer to focus on delivery of implementation plans and continue to improve regional collaboration – such as the recent decision to establish a regional, three-council waters CCO – that would in-turn benefit future regional spatial planning. It is therefore respectfully suggested that councils with newly adopted FDSs be allowed to focus on implementation, rather than commencing an early review of them in support of the 2027 Long-Term Plans.

While extending the time horizon from 30 to 50 years may provide some benefits, this proposal needs to be well thought through to ensure it does not result in unintended consequences. Extending the time horizon may lead to more speculative behaviour, increased forecasting uncertainty, cause potential misalignment between development capacity and infrastructure readiness, and undermine strategic planning's effectiveness in coordinating development and infrastructure delivery. There are also hidden costs in developing Council business processes that adapt to a 50-year timeframe, which may not be insignificant and would come at a cost to ratepayers – either directly or via the reallocation of resources from other projects.

Council acknowledges that Pillar 2 of the Going for Housing Growth programme is closely integrated with spatial planning. This is of key interest, and Council looks forward to more direction and consultation with Government over Pillar 2 and Pillar 3.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Include spatial planning in the new RM system in a manner that balances and integrates land use with infrastructure planning and investment. To enable this, stronger alignment with funding tools and decisions is recommended – particularly through legislative reform.
- Consider the implications of extending the planning horizon to 50 years, including how any risks may be managed in the system, whilst exploring how infrastructure modelling tools could improve forecasting and decision-making.
- Provide flexibility in setting infrastructure prerequisites for identified growth areas.
- Provide guidance or support to local governments to establish effective governance structures for regional spatial planning.
- Support the identification of priority development areas but suggest this be incorporated into the FDS itself rather than the Implementation Plan, which should focus on delivery rather than introducing new decisions or objectives.
- Allow councils with newly adopted FDSs to focus on implementation rather than an early review of the FDS to inform the 2027 Long-Term Plans.

2.2. Housing Growth Targets

Council is supportive of greater methodological standardisation for setting growth targets. This will continue to reduce the burden and cost on councils, and establish a greater level of confidence in the targets, the associated capacity assessments, and the planning frameworks – including spatial planning – that follow.

Council notes that clear definitions of and within such processes is important. For example, the definition of 'urban environments' and 'housing markets' will influence the final outputs of these processes. This is important for the Whangārei District, which includes a mix of urban and rural settlements and a substantial portion of lifestyle living in remote areas. In the proposed absence of explicit urban/rural boundaries, councils will benefit from clear guidance to interpret their responsibilities.

Council highlights that currently there is a lack of certainty about how the growth targets would function for councils. Predominantly, councils are responsible for unlocking growth, as opposed to delivery of housing. As such, a revision of the name of the growth targets could be to the effect of "housing capacity targets". Furthermore, Council would appreciate greater clarity over how any target and the result of achieving or not achieving the target would impact councils. This could be a link to Pillar 3, but currently that is unclear.

While standardisation is supported, council also supports retaining discretion to adjust certain methodological inputs – particularly those related to feasibility calculations. The design of long-term feasibility testing should allow for justified adjustments to both cost and value assumptions. Allowing flexibility on only one side of the feasibility equation could lead to imbalanced outcomes. To ensure a fair and robust approach, any discretion applied to feasibility testing should extend to both cost and value assumptions, or be avoided altogether. In some instances, anticipated infrastructure investment may materially influence development viability. The framework should allow councils to include commentary on future infrastructure or market changes expected to affect feasibility.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Provide guidance and standardisation of methodologies and outcomes related to housing targets and associated processes.
- Include the word 'capacity' among the growth target discussion to better represent councils' function of enabling capacity rather than delivering urban development.
- Enable councils to adjust technical inputs to both costs and values, to reflect local infrastructure investment plans, market dynamics, and anticipated long-term changes in cost and value.

2.3. Infrastructure Readiness

Council supports aligning infrastructure-readiness with anticipated demand. This approach reflects decision-making for infrastructure investment, particularly in districts such as Whangārei where growth tends to be variable or disparate, and budgets must be carefully prioritised.

The intention to improve the robustness of infrastructure assessments is also supported. However, mandatory minimum requirements may be challenging for some councils. Councils operate within varied planning, financial, and technical contexts, and may be at different stages of evidence development. A suite of recommended methodologies or templates would provide useful guidance without constraining local decision-making, or overly impacting council budgets.

Clear guidance would be helpful on how to evaluate infrastructure-readiness in relation to major infrastructure such as reservoirs and treatment plants. Consideration should be given to cumulative growth demands and how capacity constraints in major infrastructure are to be addressed over time. Council considers that assessment of infrastructure-readiness should focus on whether trunk infrastructure can feasibly be delivered at the point it is needed.

In addition to infrastructure-readiness, Council suggests that price efficiency indicators need to be better defined and understood. How the indicators operate in different development markets is not well understood, and often highly context specific. To support Governments intentions, it is suggested that Councils be provided with explanatory materials that clarify how to interpret indicator trends, how the indicators interrelate, what the underlying drivers may be, and what the appropriate policy responses could include.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Align infrastructure-readiness requirements with anticipated demand, rather than high-growth scenarios by default.
- Provide a range of recommended approaches that can be scaled and adapted to local contexts and capabilities for infrastructure assessment methodologies, avoiding the need for minimum requirements.
- Frame infrastructure-readiness around serviceability at the point of anticipated need, rather than early or blanket infrastructure commitments.
- Provide specific guidance on how to assess readiness for large-scale or strategic infrastructure (e.g. reservoirs, wastewater treatment plants), particularly in relation to cumulative network pressures and bulk capacity constraints.
- Provide explanatory materials to accompany indicators, including methodologies to distinguish land value from land plus improvements, and recommended diagnostic frameworks for interpreting trends.
- Support site analysis, market analysis and data and other relevant information before relying on price efficiency indicators to indicate zoning or planning rule changes.

2.4. Responsive planning and urban expansion

2.4.1. Responsive Planning and urban expansion

The proposal to strengthen requirements for councils to be responsive to unanticipated or out-of-sequence developments is supported in principle. However, responsiveness must be balanced with the local context, including infrastructure prioritisation, funding decisions, and the objective need for additional development capacity. These factors are critical to ensuring infrastructure providers have sufficient lead-in time to plan, fund, and deliver services. Without this, there is a risk that such development could place disproportionate pressure on infrastructure networks and council resources, without delivering net additional housing. It may also result in development occurring in areas where there is already excess capacity in sites that are planned to be, or are, infrastructure-ready.

Strategic spatial planning plays a vital role in aligning growth with infrastructure investment, environmental constraints, and community wellbeing. Unplanned sprawl and leapfrogging development often undermine these objectives by increasing car dependency, reducing walkability and public transport viability, and disconnecting new development from existing services and communities. These patterns also dilute efforts to consolidate growth in serviced areas, potentially diminishing returns on prior infrastructure investment and undermining drivers of affordability.

The proposals would benefit from clearer guidance on leapfrog development, such as whether land between developments is expected to urbanise, or if remote development is acceptable with private infrastructure. Without clear guidance, this could lead to scattered growth, less efficient services, and higher infrastructure costs.

To manage this, tools such as infrastructure triggers and sequencing tied to strategic transport investment are recommended. These are necessary to prevent premature development, and to ensure growth occurs in areas that can be made liveable. Spatial planning provides the appropriate framework to identify future growth areas, outline infrastructure requirements, and time delivery through a staged approach, beginning with spatial planning, followed by structure planning, infrastructure delivery, and then zoning.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Ensure that responsive planning requirements can accommodate variations in local development capacity, housing need, and infrastructure readiness.
- Avoid relying solely on scale thresholds (e.g. 50 dwellings) as triggers for policy obligations, as these may not reflect broader strategic or infrastructure considerations.
- Allow councils to apply clear, objective criteria when assessing unanticipated or out-of-sequence development proposals. These criteria should include whether there is an identified shortfall in feasible and serviceable zoned land; whether the proposal aligns with, or can be integrated into, the adopted spatial planning framework; whether infrastructure can be delivered without diverting funding or delaying programmed infrastructure projects; and how all capital and long-term operational costs for infrastructure will be funded and maintained.
- Support policies that allow councils to balance decisions with economic efficiency, infrastructure provision and investment, environmental constraints, and locally determined outcomes.
- Avoid policies that enable development in the absence of objective need, particularly where such development imposes undue financial or operational burdens on councils and ratepayers.

2.4.2. Growth Pays for Growth

The principle that growth should pay for growth is fundamental to the financial sustainability of infrastructure provision and is supported in both principle and practice. While this matter is expected to be addressed more directly under Pillar 2, its intersection with responsive planning mechanisms warrants careful attention.

Out-of-sequence development proposals frequently generate expectations that infrastructure will be prioritised to accommodate them. While initial capital costs may be met by developers, the long-term cost of maintaining and renewing that infrastructure typically falls to councils and wider ratepayers. Where such infrastructure is inefficient to maintain, ratepayers may ultimately bear additional costs. These financial pressures are compounded by the broader externalities associated with unplanned development, including increased vehicle dependency, congestion, inefficient service delivery, and added pressure on community facilities.

Even where full cost recovery is achieved, there is a residual risk that resulting development will either be unaffordable or delivered at low quality, leading to negative downstream consequences for residents, communities, and the public sector. This reinforces the need to ensure that responsive planning mechanisms do not reduce infrastructure quality standards.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Require unanticipated or out-of-sequence developments to fund all necessary enabling infrastructure and a proportionate share of downstream infrastructure upgrades affected by the development.
- Address the residual risks of long-term operational burden that remains with councils and ratepayers.
- Ensure that responsive planning mechanisms do not undermine infrastructure investment strategies or infrastructure quality.

2.5. Urban intensification and mixed-use neighbourhoods

Council supports further standardisation of intensification and mixed-use outcomes. This is useful in lessening the impact on councils to undertake these planning measures in appropriate locations in the face of localised, and often minority, community opposition.

Council recommends including provisions that allow local authorities to assess where intensification and mixed-use zoning may be less suitable, and to respond accordingly.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Enable greater use of intensification – particularly around large public infrastructure investment – and mixed-use outcomes.
- Consider matters that may preclude or affect those intensification or mixed-use outcomes that should be assessed by councils to account for local contexts.

2.6. Planning controls and externalities

Council supports the objective of reducing regulatory overreach and ensuring planning rules do not impose disproportionate or unnecessary barriers on development. Planning interventions should be evidence-based, proportionate, and clearly linked to outcomes. However, limiting the justification for rules solely to the management of externalities may have unintended impacts and costs to councils.

Certain planning requirements, such as cycle parking, minimum floor areas, or access to private outdoor space, may not strictly manage externalities but do still serve legitimate public policy purposes. These include enabling transport mode shift, safeguarding public health, and ensuring minimum housing quality. Such rules may impose internalised costs but generate broader public benefits. Council would appreciate further analysis as to any costs that may be passed on to local government, and if that was the case, what support could be provided to alleviate the burden to ratepayers.

For example, with the removal of minimum open space requirements, residents – individuals, or families with kids, will still require open space for recreation and exercise. Council recognises there are social benefits to greater communal open space; however, if that is not provided by the market then councils will be expected to increase spending to acquire land and provide more parks and open space. While there may be other unintended consequences relating to health, it is the potential impacts on councils that should be immediately explored alongside discussions of the role of local government.

Minimum housing quality standards also play a role in preventing longer-term negative social and economic outcomes. Poor-quality housing can result in higher public expenditure in health, education, and policing. Moreover, low-income households are often least able to exercise market choice, and regulation serves a protective function to ensure basic living conditions are met.

To actively contribute to the successful delivery of the Government's 'Going for Housing Growth' outcomes, Council **recommends** the following:

- Avoid defining externalities too narrowly and recognise that some rules serve important public functions.
- Account for any costs to councils if externalities are removed to lessen the burden on local rate payers.

3. General comments

In addition to the specific comments and recommendations above the following general comments are provided.

3.1. Reduced role for local decision-making with additional local costs and risks

The new Resource Management system appears to represent a significant shift towards increasing centralised decision-making and reducing the role of local decision-making. While the intent is acknowledged and supported, we also support continued local voice and variation where appropriate. A 'one-size fits-all' approach is not always the most appropriate solution. If the new system does significantly reduce local decision-making, we suggest that any indirect costs of this are explored by government, as it is likely these would land with councils to resolve, further increasing the pressure on debt levels or rate rises.

3.2. Bipartisan approach to Resource Management Reform

It is noted the current and previous governments have highlighted Resource Management Reform as key actions – which Council supports. However, the uncertainty and jeopardy of political cycles has delayed that process. Major reform programmes are more likely to succeed when they are developed cohesively and have bipartisan political support, ensuring longevity and giving councils the ability to get on and deliver the development capacity and infrastructure our communities need. We support the Government in attempts to achieve this.

3.3. Limited Engagement and Consultation

Given the scale and pace of current reforms, there is a real risk that local government, the planning sector, iwi and hapū, stakeholders, and the general public will not have sufficient capacity to engage as effectively or constructively as desired.

Council values the input of hapū and has made a commitment to working with hapū, which is evident in our Te Kārearea Strategic Partnership Committee. Due to the scale of the proposals and timeframes of consultation we have not had adequate opportunity to engage with Te Kārearea or local hapū. This could risk damaging relationships with hapū and compromise councils' and Central Government's obligations to take into account the principles of the Treaty of Waitangi (Te Tiriti o Waitangi) as part of RMA decision-making.



In reply please quote:

Plan Stop Direction

Or ask for:

Dominic Kula – General Manager Planning and Development

24 July 2025

Hon Chris Bishop
 Freepost Parliament
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Dear Minister Bishop,

Plan Stop Direction

Whangarei District Council (**Council**) welcomes the Government's direction to prepare for the transition to a new resource management system. We support efforts to streamline planning and ensure that councils are focused on work that aligns with future legislative frameworks.

Council supports the general intention of the 'plan stop' proposed to be enacted under the Resource Management (Consenting and Other System Changes) Bill (**the Bill**). However, Council is concerned about the implications of this taking effect before clarity is provided on the replacement system to the RMA.

There is a risk that essential work, including initiatives that would logically inform a future spatial plan and/or would improve the effectiveness of our District Plan, is halted without a clear and timely pathway for resumption. Our current plan change work programme has been developed to prioritise chapters/ topics in response to Government's reform direction with a focus on ensuring our District Plan is as up to date as possible for transition to the new system. This includes plan changes specifically focussed on streamlining and simplifying resource consenting processes

Our Council has made great strides in recent years to build relationships with our local hapū, with the planning work that our staff have been carrying out playing a key part in this. To put a hold on all plan changes for local government, could have damaging effects on these relationships. Council therefore requests that the Government:

1. Develops criteria for the ministerial exemption process that explicitly accommodate plan changes that:

- Are consistent with the anticipated direction of the new planning system;
- Have involved significant resource investment and community engagement;
- Would be materially compromised by a pause in progress;
- Protect cultural heritage and provide for the relationship of Māori and their culture and traditions with their ancestral lands, water, sites, waahi tapu, and other taonga;
- Provide for effectiveness and efficiency improvements for resource consenting processes.

2. Provides clarity as soon as possible on the exemption application process, including:

- What documentation is required to support an application;
- Whether a plan review that does not yet have a decision to notify a plan change can be considered for an exemption;
- Whether the criteria will be flexible and sensitive to the unique circumstances councils face;
- How existing agreements with hapū and iwi will be considered;
- The timeframes that will apply to Government in making a decision on an exemption application.

This clarity is critical given the timing of upcoming local body elections. Providing only three months for local government to apply for exemptions from when Bill is enacted means that local government elected members most likely will be left out of the exemption application process.

Council remains committed to ensuring that our planning framework is fit for purpose and future-ready. To assist in that we are seeking that the Government provides an exemption pathway for plan change work that ensures a smoother transition of current plans into the new system.

Yours faithfully



HWM Vince Cocurullo

His Worship the Mayor



Cllr Ken Couper

Strategy, Planning and Democracy Chair



Minister of Housing
Minister for Infrastructure
Minister Responsible for RMA Reform
Minister of Transport
Leader of the House
Associate Minister of Finance
Associate Minister for Sport and Recreation

CB-COR1763/CORM-4268

Vince Cocurullo
Mayor
Whangarei District Council

Ken Couper
Strategy, Planning and Democracy Chair
Whangarei District Council

By email: mayor@wdc.govt.nz

Dear Vince and Ken,

Thank you for your letter of 24 July 2025 outlining your general support for preparing councils for the transition to a new resource management system, and for raising your concerns about the impact that the plan stop may have on essential workstreams before clarity is provided on the replacement to the Resource Management Act 1991.

I value Whangarei District Council's dedication to building and maintaining relationships with local hapū, as well as progressing with its current plan change work programme, particularly in areas aligned with Government priorities.

As you are aware, there will be exemptions for some plan and policy statement changes and reviews that are currently being progressed, and for some new plan and policy statement changes or reviews. Thank you for providing your thoughts on the exemption process.

While I am unable to comment on the status of the changes to the resource management system and how they will impact councils, once the legislation has been passed, guidance will be provided on how the exemptions will work and what plan making they may apply to. The intention is that essential plan making can continue.

You can find announcements about the Government's resource management reform programme on the Beehive website at: <https://www.beehive.govt.nz/portfolio/nationalactnew-zealand-first-coalition-government-2023-2026/rma-reform>.

You can also find additional information on the Ministry for the Environment website at: <https://environment.govt.nz/news/reforming-the-resource-management-system-replacing-the-rma/>.

Thank you for your correspondence on this important matter.

Yours sincerely,

Hon Chris Bishop
Minister Responsible for RMA Reform

Operations Report Strategy and Democracy

September 2025

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1 Executive Summary

In August 2025, the Strategy and Democracy Group continued to deliver a broad and complex programme of work across its four core areas – Democracy and Assurance, Strategy, Corporate Planning, and Māori Outcomes.

The **Democracy Team** is managing the 2025 Local Elections while maintaining high compliance with legislative requirements despite resource pressures.

The **Strategy Team** progressed key statutory and strategic projects, though some deliverables have been delayed due to budget constraints and competing priorities.

Corporate Planning focused on preparing for the incoming Council, supporting audit processes, and planning for the next Annual and Long Term Plans, with legislative changes influencing future direction.

Māori Outcomes advanced the development of engagement frameworks and cultural capability initiatives, while continuing to support hapū and iwi engagement across Council projects. Despite ongoing challenges, the Group remains committed to delivering transparent, inclusive, and future-focused outcomes for the Whangārei District.

2 Democracy and Assurance

2.1 Health and Safety

Health and safety review conversations happen at this time of the year; this will include a desktop walk through of the health and safety within the Chambers and Mayoral Suite areas. Staff continue to monitor wellbeing of staff as resources continue to be stretched, and the Department remains under pressure.

2.2 Current Priorities

- Local Elections 2025. Voting papers due out Tuesday 9 September, voting will be happening at the time of this meeting.
- Election voting ballot boxes and bins are in ten locations across the district – at least one in every ward, along with a mobile ballot box on the library bus.
- Adhering to Legislative requirements. This includes meeting the LGOIMA requirements for Council meetings (agenda preparation and public notices) as well as responding to Official Information requests and investigating any reported privacy breaches under the Privacy Act 2020.
- Monitoring legislation changes that are being proposed and being passed by Central Government.

2.3 Performance measures and compliance

Aim: Our Democratic functions are transparent and meet the legislative requirements.

The table below is reflective of the compliance figures for the new financial year – 2025-26.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 Target	Compliance Year to Date
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11.1.1 Responses to requests for information made under the Local Government Official Information Act 1987 and the Privacy Act 2020 are provided within relevant statutory timeframes.

≥95%

98.39%

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 Target	Compliance Year to Date
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11.1.2 Percentage of Council, committee and hearing agendas that meet relevant legislative timeframes.

100%

100%

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 Target	Compliance Year to Date
---------------------	------------------	-------------------------

11.1.3 Percentage of Council recommendations that are not altered by amendment in chambers for reasons of ambiguity.

≥95%

100%

Current challenges/issues

Resource Challenges:

- Continuing to process Local Government Official Information and Meetings Act requests within legislative timeframes has been a challenge due to the increased number of requests and complexity of those received, alongside high workloads across the organisation with competing priorities. There has been an increase in new LGOIMA's needing to be lodged for further information originating from previous responses.

- The whole department works with the operational staff, the strategic leadership team, and the elected member group. This organisational wide stakeholder group creates a unique dynamic for the team to work with. The team are a strong group but lean in number, they work with the resources available. This means that there needs to be continuous pragmatic prioritisation to ensure that important and urgent tasks are delivered first.

2.4 Overview of Operational Activities for July

The Democracy Team supported the following meetings and processed the following licensing applications, during the month of July:

Meeting	Number
Council	3
Committee	5
Council Briefing	2
Council Workshop	1
District Licensing Committee activities	
License applications	18
DLC hearing	0

Local Government Elections 2025 (LGE2025)

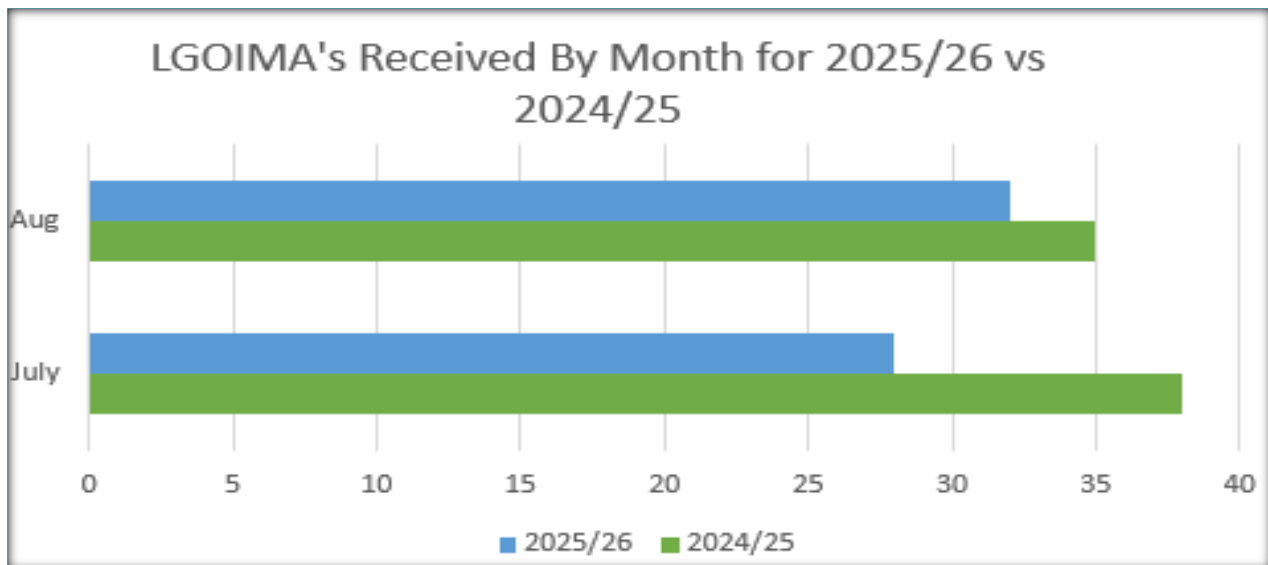
Nominations closed on 1 August. As part of the campaign to promote the elections, electoral staff have for the first time compiled a list of 'Meet the Candidate' events and made 2-minute candidate videos, available on the WDC website. These initiatives have been well received by the public. Electoral staff are planning for the 'Vote' phase of LGE2025, which runs from Tuesday, 9 September to Saturday, 11 October (12 noon).

There has been a steady flow of people to the Elections Hub during August to check and update enrolment details and get information on LGE2025. Electors who do not receive their voting papers will be able to complete a special vote at the Customer Services centres at Te Iwitahi and Ruakaka during the voting period. Drop off locations for postal votes are as follows:

- Te Iwitahi (Drop off and special votes)
- Service Centre at iSite (Drop off votes)
- Whangarei Central Library (Drop off votes)
- Ruakākā Service Centre (Drop off and special votes)
- Pak n save – Whangarei (Drop off votes)
- GAS Station Maungatapere (Drop off votes)
- Parua Bay FourSquare (Drop off votes)
- Hikurangi FourSquare (Drop off votes)
- Woolworths Regent (Drop off votes)
- Woolworths Tikipunga (Drop off votes)
- Whangarei Mobile Library Bus (Drop off votes)

Official Information Act Requests (LGOIMAs)

Statistics for official information requests are reported for the current financial year, which runs from 1 July 2025 to 30 June 2026. To date, the team has processed 62 requests in this financial year, with 32 received in August. This was slightly less than was received in the same month for the previous financial year.



One request exceeded its legislative due date during this period, primarily due to high work volumes, the complexity of requests, and multiple deadlines falling on the same day. The overdue request was issued the following day.

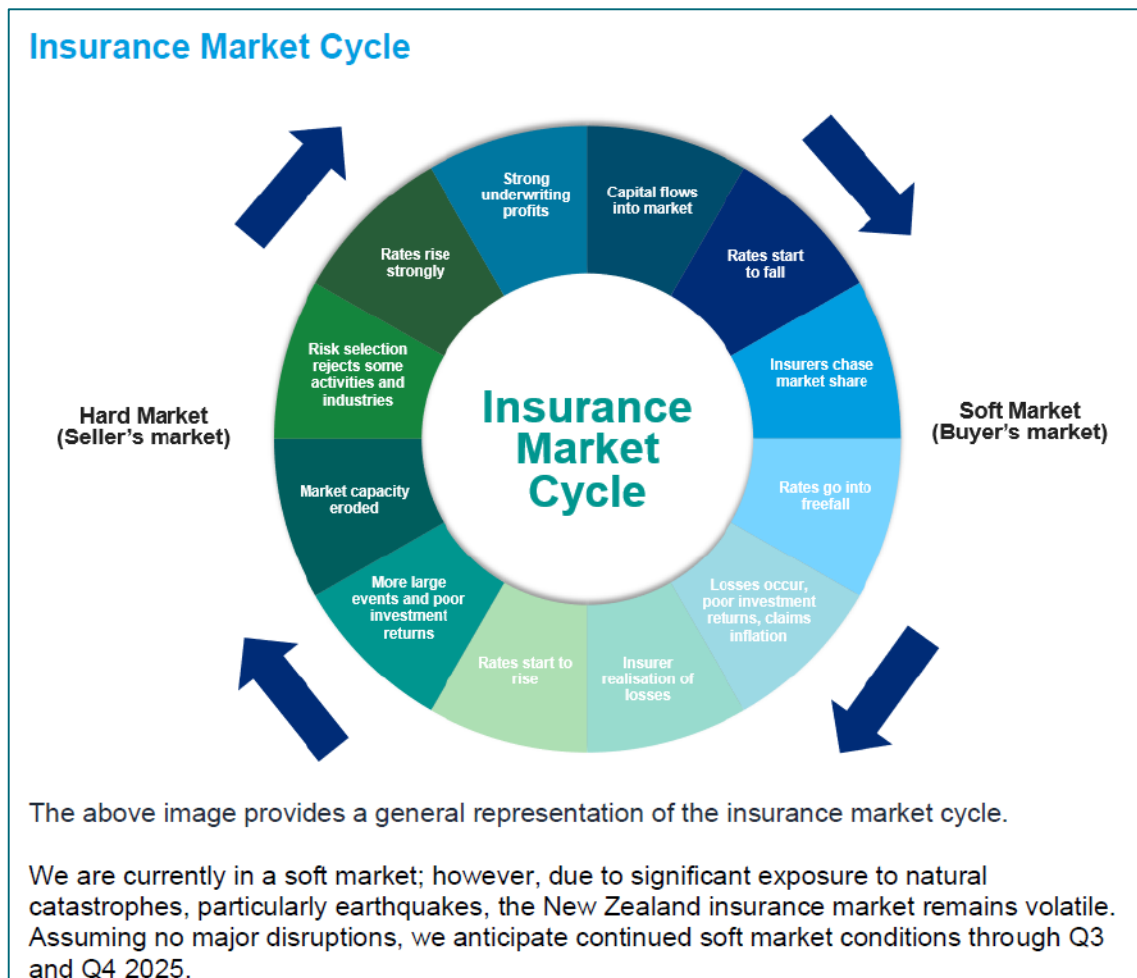
Overdue LGOIMAs per Month		
Month	Total received	Total overdue
July 2025	30	1
August 2025	32	0

Given the complexity of the requests received, increased support and guidance from the Legal Team is needed in more cases than we have seen. This causes challenges given the resource constraints and timelines. Staff continue to work on reviewing and revising processes to ensure that legislative timelines can be achieved.

Insurance

Council's insurance broker Marsh met with staff on 14 August 2025 to begin discussions about the 1 November 2025 insurance renewal. The majority of Council's insurance policies are part of this renewal, including material damage (i.e. property), underground infrastructure, and motor vehicles.

Marsh report a softening in the insurance market, which provides reason for Council to be cautiously optimistic about the upcoming renewal terms and premiums. The market cycle is shown below, including commentary from Marsh on the outlook leading up to the renewal.



Risk management

Agenda reports were completed throughout August for the 3 September 2025 Risk and Audit Committee meeting.

Elected Members and the Strategic Leadership Team were asked to complete a Summary of Triennium 2022-2025 Questionnaire. Survey results from the questionnaire have been received and this feedback will play an important role in induction planning for the new Council.

Internal Audit

Due to the extensive scope of files requiring review by our contractor, there has been a delay in receiving the final report. As a result, the report will not be ready in time for the Risk and Audit Committee meeting scheduled for 3 September 2025. Instead, it will be presented at the March Risk and Audit committee meeting.

2.4.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

It is recognised that supporting the democratic process brings with it obligations under Te Tiriti and The Treaty, which the department try to support through provision of democratic services. Interpretation and implementation of these principles in relation to the legislation, continues however, to test the status quo.

2.5 Legislation changes or updates

Staff will continue to advise Council on current legislation and are monitoring legislative changes that are coming through parliament for implementation. This includes support to changes in delegations being requested following legislative changes from central government.

2.6 Future Planning / What's coming next?

The Democracy and Assurance department has a reoccurring, rolling programme of work relating to the Council meetings and legislative deadlines. The other areas of the team work on a request basis so workloads fluctuate.

The Democracy team is managing the LGE2025. Voting papers will be distributed from 09 September and the team will be managing a network of 10 ballot boxes across the district and 2 mobile boxes. This includes ensuring that boxes are closed and collected at 12 noon on 11 October.

The team are also looking at the induction arrangements for the Council for the next triennium, to ensure a good opportunity for the incoming Council to understand the business of council and determine how they intend to work as a team for the betterment of the district.

The agenda preparation review system (E-scribe) is due to be upgraded this year. Staff are waiting for information about additional functionality that the team and other departments can utilise. Timeframe for changes is second half of the year with updates in place for the start of the next triennium of Council.

3 Strategy

3.1 Health and Safety

The existing team workload is high for the 2025-26 financial year as demonstrated by the draft work programme included in section 3.4. The department is managing more frequent illness in the winter months – and recently has been experienced in the bylaws and statutory policy space, as well as the placemaking programme space.

3.2 Performance measures and compliance

Our policies and strategies remain up to date and relevant to the community.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 Target	Compliance Year to Date
Percentage of statutory policies, bylaws, plans and strategies that are reviewed with the relevant statutory timeframes (LTP 2024-34, 11.2.1)	100%	95% (35 of 37 statutory documents compliant).

3.3 Current challenges/issues/risks

3.3.1 Timing of project deliverables with available budgets

The department work programme is ambitious and is staged according to budget. With the need for Council to absorb \$5million of high-risk operational costs into existing budgets, the department work programme has paused some project deliverables for the Knowledge Precinct Plan and wider programme until there is more certainty around the overall organisational operational budget. This has been communicated to project partners. Staff have also been required to support other projects and works within Council, and so this has diverted some resource away from core team work this past month.

3.4 Strategic Planning Department work programme

Workstream, Programmes & Projects	Dept Lead	Statutory
Bylaws & statutory policies	7 projects	
Alcohol Control Bylaw	WM	y
Public Places Bylaw	WM	y
Control of Advertising Signs Bylaw	WM	y
<i>Food Businesses Grading Bylaw</i>	external contract	y
Control of Vehicles on Beaches Bylaw	WM	y
Stormwater Management Bylaw	WM	y
Wastewater Bylaw	WM	y
Spatial Planning	6 projects	
FDS Implementation Plan	HS	y
Regional Deals (unplanned)	DM	n
Housing and Business Model (improvements and review, incl. Alignment with LTP)	HS	y
Knowledge Precinct Plan	LE	n
Placemaking Programme	3 projects	
Raumanga Placemaking Plan	CGP	n
Monitoring & Reviews of existing placemaking plans	CGP	n
Ruakākā Placemaking Plan	CGP	n
Climate Adaptation	9 projects	
Climate Adaptation Programme		
Whangaruru/Oakura - Community Adaptation Project -Pilot	RN	n
Whangarei Urban Flood Strategy	RN	n
Tangata Whenua-led Climate Planning Fund (BoF)		
Te Waiariki, Ngāti Kororā, Ngāti Takapari Hapū Iwi Trust (Risk Assessment & Adaptation Plan)	RN	n
BoF - Projects 2- 8 pending confirmation of legal and data agreements.	RN	n
Te Tai Tokerau Adaptation Strategy Implementation	RN	n
Te Ao Māori Decision Making Framework	BA	n
Housing Strategy Programme		
Pensioner Housing	HS	n
Papakāinga regulatory applications (BoF)	BA	n
Housing Strategy Review & Implementation	HS	n
Other	13 projects	
Regional Accessibility Strategy Implementation	All	n

Welcoming Communities Strategic Action Plan	HS	n
Regional Infrastructure Plan (unplanned)		n
Infrastructure Modelling		
Coastal Management Strategy Review		
Reserve Management Plan Review		
RLTP & RPTP Review		
Upper North Island Strategic Alliance (UNISA)	BA	
Site-specific urban design assessments	LE / DM	
Strategic Oversight on Resource Consents & Development Proposals	LE / DM	

3.5 Overview of Operational Activities for August 2025 & Next steps

Project	What we did in August	Next steps
Spatial Planning		
<i>City Centre Programme: Knowledge Precinct Plan</i>	Staff prepared the committee report to present the engagement summary. Staff have also been working on further site analysis to understand the community and stakeholder feedback. This includes more detailed design thinking on Cafler Park as well as transport options into and around the precinct. Council approved the decision to accept funding from Forum North Trust to procure professional services that will progress the Lyric theatre and inform the Precinct Plan. Staff are also planning for various budget scenarios to further progress this project later in 2025.	Staff will present to Strategy, Planning and Development Committee on engagement findings. Staff will also be working with Forum North Trust to action their needs with their provided finding through consultants. Staff will continue to refine the options for the precinct, and work towards a draft plan. PSB actions not listed.
<i>Placemaking Programme</i>	Staff continued to work internally with the Community Infrastructure Projects Team to collaborate in the development of the Master Plan for Tarewa Park. The signing of the engagement agreements with local hapū and whānau was interrupted by staff sickness. Conversations will re-start in September.	Staff will begin working on the first stage of Māori engagement. Staff will also prepare content and set dates for the 2nd round of community engagement.
<i>Future Development Strategy (FDS) and Implementation Plan</i>	Staff have continued socialising the FDS with operational teams across WDC. This also includes teams working on relevant projects to the FDS to ensure alignment across outcomes and deliverables. Staff have continued preparing background work to inform the FDS Implementation Plan, meeting weekly with NRC staff to jointly complete this work. The Implementation Plan is a requirement under the NPS on Urban Development (NPS-UD).	Continue socialising the FDS and connecting with relevant teams to embed the Strategy across the organisation as well as NRC. Staff will begin working on the first draft of the Implementation Plan, including with internal groups and targeted external stakeholders.
Statutory Policies & Bylaws		
<i>Food Businesses Grading Bylaw (consultant-led)</i>	Statutory review completed at Council meeting on 28 August 2025.	Draft amendments to be presented to upcoming Council briefing for discussion
<i>Public Places Bylaw</i>	Developed draft clauses for a Public Nuisance and Safety Bylaw and a Public Trading, Events	Continued engagement with key external stakeholders to

Project	What we did in August	Next steps
	and Filming Bylaw in line with Council direction issued at 29 April 2025 meeting.	inform draft new bylaws for Council's consideration.
<i>Control of Advertising Signs Bylaw</i>	Developed draft clauses for a new Signs Bylaw in line with Council direction issued at 29 April 2025 meeting.	Continued engagement with key external stakeholders to inform draft new bylaws for Council's consideration.
<i>Control of Vehicles on Beaches Bylaw</i>	Research and analysis for draft findings report to inform Council's review.	Early stakeholder engagement to inform statutory review of bylaw.
<i>Alcohol Control Bylaw</i>	Council decision on 28 August 2025 to add more coastal areas to its register of alcohol bans.	Staff to update register of alcohol bans, add definition of "public place" to maps and update website with accessible alt text for blind and low-vision people.
Climate Change		
WDC led		
<i>Climate Adaptation Programme – Whangaruru/ Ōākura catchment</i>	Adapterra has incorporated feedback from both WDC and Ngātiwai into the scoping report for the Whangaruru/Ōākura climate adaptation pilot project.	Engage Adapterra to develop Project Plan, draft tender documents, and support drafting the Engagement Plan.
<i>Tangata whenua-led adaptation - Better Off Funding</i>	Project management support has been engaged to oversee the fund and ensure deliverables are effectively managed. Engagement continues with recipients as progress is made towards formalising the next phase of project delivery.	Confirm and sign funding agreements, with all projects contracted and underway by the end of September 2025.
Regional Collaboration		
<i>Climate Adaptation Te Tai Tokerau (CATT)</i>	Two WDC staff members are now trained Climate Fresk facilitators. This role involves guiding participants through a collaborative learning process using Climate Fresk, a globally recognised educational tool that simplifies complex climate change concepts into an engaging, accessible, and action-focused format. The training was funded by NRC through the CATT collaboration.	Deliver internal team training, facilitate quarterly staff workshops (12 participants per session), and roll out targeted sessions for the Senior Leadership Team (SLT).
Upper North Island Strategic Alliance (UNISA)		
<i>Officer Working Group</i>	Attendance in working group to ensure Whangarei and Northland perspectives are included in strategic planning and advocacy for the upper North Island. Current priorities include	Staff to participate in collective multi criteria analysis of projects to be included in the IDP.

Project	What we did in August	Next steps
	development of an Infrastructure Development Plan (IDP) for UNISA. understanding government direction and impacts on local government (Future of Local Government, Development Levies) Updating value proposition and the UNI 'story' (due end of 2025). No update available due to staff being on leave.	

3.5.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

The Department work programme presents risks to Council's relationship with its Te Tiriti partners, primarily due to project timeframes and resourcing impacting the ability to have meaningful engagement. Project teams, facilitated by Māori Outcomes, have communicated the benefits of working together while also communicating the constraints and risks transparently to hapū. This is an ongoing risk.

4 Corporate Planning

4.1 Health and Safety

No health and safety issues identified.

4.2 Current Priorities

Over August the department focused on four main tasks:

- **Preparing for new Council:** preparing briefing on Action Plan for 2026-27 Annual Plan to go to Council in September, early planning for next Long Term Plan, contribution to planning for induction of new Council after the Elections.
- **Annual Report and audit processes:** Coordination and support across the organisation of non-financial performance measures data capture for Annual Report 2024-25. Engagement with external auditors and internal managers on the assurance process for performance measures for Annual Report 2024-25.
- **Central Government Reform programme:** Briefing to Council on Local Government (System Improvements) Amendment Bill and possible implications for Council.
- **Policy development:** Socialisation of a draft Council Submissions Policy.

4.3 Performance measures and compliance

The Corporate Planning Department does not have publicly reported performance measures. The Department has oversight of the organisation's monthly and annual reporting on performance measures and compliance. Other deliverables include coordinating the production of the Long Term Plan, Annual Plan and aspects of the Annual Report.

4.4 Current challenges/issues

Planning for next year's Annual Plan and the Long-Term Plan would normally have started by now, but with the Council Elections, further planning is on hold until strategic direction for the Plans is provided by the new Council. This may mean that the time available for planning and undertaking all the various elements towards the development of an Annual Plan will be more pressurised.

4.5 Corporate Planning Department work programme

Annual Plan 2026-27	planned
CPM 2024-25 (incl. Residents' Survey)	in progress
Annual Report 2024-25	in progress
Annual Plan 2026-27	planned
CPM 2025-26 (incl. Residents' Survey)	planned
Annual Report 2025-26	planned
Long Term Plan 2027-37	planned

4.6 Overview of Operational Activities for August 2025 and Next Steps

Project	What we did in August	Next steps
Corporate Planning		
<i>2025-26 Annual Plan (AP26)</i>	Prepared Briefing on Action Plan for 2026-27 Annual Plan for Council 11 th September.	Post Election – Action Plan with background information presented as part of

Project	What we did in August	Next steps
		induction for EMs seeking early direction.
<i>2024-25 Corporate Performance Management System (CPM)</i>	Highlighted issues with year-end rollover with ICT and completed an assessment of the problem with them. Escalated to TechOne Australia as we suspect the issues is a result of a fault with the initial setup done by them last year for the new LTP. SSP system notes largely completed (Waters outstanding) and uploaded to Kete and Deloitte Connect for audit.	Continue to work with ICT and TechOne Australia to achieve 2025-26 rollover.
<i>2024-25 Annual Report (AR25)</i>	Finalised activity profiles including DM & GM sign-off. Uploaded to Deloitte Connect for audit and forwarded to Design for initial layout of the Report. Initial liaison with audit for non-financials.	Work with responsible staff and audit to conclude audit review of non-financial performance measures. Update design with any changes required by audit. Provide presentation slides for non-financial section of workshop for elected members.
<i>2027-37 Long Term Plan (LTP37)</i>	Manager attended the Taituarā Community Plan Forum to share insights with other corporate planners across the sector on preparing for the next LTP. This included presentations on: the economic backdrop and how local government might respond; working with your senior leadership team; using AI in the LTP process; the impact of creation of Water Services CCO on LTP; insights from OAG review of LTP24; and insights from Beca LTP Tool. Connections made with corporate planners from Kaipara District Council, Northland Regional Council and Far North District Council. Regular engagements with these colleagues planned every 8 weeks to seek opportunities for greater collaboration and efficiencies across our organisations.	Prepare materials for new Council induction on corporate planning and LTP process and key decisions to be made over the next 18 months. Finalise draft LTP Project Plan. Prepare draft Engagement and Consultation Plan. Commence work on Environmental Scan and Strategy Stocktake.
<i>SSP measures internal assurance for audit</i>	Follow up on 'System Notes' documenting procedures and review of notes with feedback back to managers. Update to audit of our risk assessment across suite of measures. Update to SLT on progress and next steps.	Audit to be done 17 September to 3 October. Team to assist audit with enquiries.

Project	What we did in August	Next steps
<i>Submissions Policy</i>	Continuing to incorporate internal feedback and take policies to OLT and SLT for review.	Once approved by SLT submit for review by Council.

4.6.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

No current risks to the Tiriti Relationship. Engagement with Te Kārearea, Te Huinga and local hapū representatives will be an important part of future engagement plans for the Annual Plan and Long Term Plan.

4.7 Legislation changes or updates

Government decisions on our Water Services Delivery Plan to be made in October 2025 with an implementation period from November 2025 to July 2027 will impact on the scope and content of future Annual Plans, Annual Report and the 2027-37 Long Term Plan. Similarly, there may be changes required to our processes and content for future corporate planning documents that come from the enactment of the draft Local Government (System Improvements) Amendment Bill and the Regulatory Standards Bill.

4.8 Future Planning / What's coming next?

Business as Usual – presenting to Council in September on our Action Plan for next Annual Plan and Long Term Plan and preparing materials for new Council induction; finalisation of data and information for the 2024/25 Annual Report and supporting audit.

5 Māori Outcomes

5.1 Health and Safety

No work environment related issues raised.

5.2 Current Priorities

A key focus of internal efforts has been the development of the Māori Engagement System to guide operational teams in their engagement with mana whenua, hapū and iwi. The initial stages of this system were launched during Puanga Matariki, informed by internal needs assessments and ongoing staff input. The system is intended to serve as a centralised resource to promote best-practice engagement, cultural safety, and alignment with Council's statutory obligations under the LGA and RMA.

Matakohe have now been fully onboarded into the organisation and are conducting the necessary workshops to begin shaping the design of the Māori Engagement Framework. Their expertise will help ensure the framework reflects both Council's statutory responsibilities and the expectations of mana whenua, hapū and iwi, while embedding consistency and clarity across engagement practices.

Testing of the Fees and Koha Policy and its operational framework has shown that engagement scenarios across Council are far broader and more complex than initially scoped, requiring expanded guidance to remain relevant across diverse departments and functions. While cultural capability is being supported through a range of formal and informal activities, the testing process has highlighted that, despite Māori Outcomes' involvement across many workstreams, the scale and complexity of the organisation continue to expose blind spots when new projects, events, or decisions arise.

For an organisation-wide Cultural Capability Framework, deliberate investment is required to ensure it reflects the evolving realities of Council operations and supports the development of a more culturally competent and responsive organisation. This cannot be delivered off the side of a desk but requires dedicated resource and long-term commitment.

5.3 Performance measures and compliance

To maintain and improve opportunities for Māori to contribute to local government decision-making processes.

Performance Measure	2025 – 26 target	Compliance
Engage the collective hapū of Whangārei each quarter throughout the reporting period to discuss matters of importance to tangata whenua and Council. (LTP 2024-34 11.3.1)	100%	Engagement continues to be facilitated across individual hapū of Whangārei. The scheduling of meetings of the collective of Whangārei Hapū might be compromised considering RAG directions which target key engagement levers.
Engage with Te Huinga each quarter in the reporting period to discuss matters of importance to Te Huinga and Council. (LTP 2024-34 11.3.2)	100%	Engagement continues with Te Huinga. Agenda specific meetings will be scheduled for the new financial year.
Design and distribute an annual survey to Māori to support monitoring outcomes for Māori in contributing to local government decision-making processes. (LTP 2024-34 11.3.3)	75%	Scope and intent of survey yet to be finalised.

Produce a Tiriti audit, review and implement all recommendations by 30 June 2027. (LTP 2024-34 11.3.4)

75%

The auditors have now consolidated both the Stage One and Stage Two reports into a single report. Report has now been received by both Te Kārearea and Council. Assurance will incorporate recommendations for monitoring.

5.4 Current challenges/issues

In the absence of established frameworks and policies, Māori Outcomes provides support to departments to navigate engagement with mana whenua, hapū and iwi. This often requires case-by-case guidance to ensure engagement is culturally appropriate.

5.4.1 Risk to the Tiriti Relationship

Māori engagement is shaped by cultural, historical, relational, and societal complexities, requiring local intelligence and expertise to ensure effective and meaningful relationships. For Council, Māori engagement aligns with both general and Treaty-based statutory obligations, including the responsibility to consider the views, diversity, and interests of all communities, while maintaining and enhancing opportunities for Māori to contribute to local government decision-making processes.

Māori engagement is fostered across three tiers for which Whangārei district-based hapū are represented.

Te Kārearea - Te Huinga - Ngā Hapū o Whangārei

- Te Kārearea Strategic Partnership Standing Committee is a Council committee where half of the fourteen-member composition consists of hapū-appointed representatives.
- Te Huinga is a hapū forum established to provide an interface with Whangārei District Council who also facilitate hapū member appointments to Te Kārearea.

While Te Huinga and Te Kārearea serve as the primary collective representation bodies for Whangārei hapū, not all hapū actively participate in Te Huinga or the appointment process for Te Kārearea:

- To uphold hapū agency and ensure broader engagement coverage, many hapū hold direct relationships with Council and an informal forum also exists to enable all Whangārei hapū to engage on priority Council matters, programmes, and activities.

Challenges in Ensuring Comprehensive Engagement with Māori

Although these three tiers provide a structured approach to Māori engagement, several challenges remain:

- Capacity and capability constraints within hapū, particularly in non-resourced working spaces.
- Diverse urban and rural priorities, leading to varying levels of engagement and influence.
- The need to balance formal representation structures with informal mechanisms to support prior and informed engagement across all hapū.

These complexities underscore the ongoing need for flexible and adaptive engagement approaches to ensure Whangārei hapū can meaningfully participate in decision-making processes.

5.5 Overview of Operational Activities for August

Cultural Capability support for:

- Engagement System | Continued development of internal Māori Engagement Hub – including templates, best practice guidelines, and trigger system
- Waiata Sessions | Fortnightly staff sessions in Manaia Theatre to build cultural capability and shared practice
- Indian Consul General Visit | Cultural support provided for civic event including pōwhiri coordination, waiata tautoko, and tikanga guidance
- Takahiwai Marae – Patuharakeke Focus Group Hui | Supported hapū-led evening engagement alongside various internal and external stakeholders
- Film Industry Link-up | Facilitated connection between local hapū and production teams to uphold cultural protocols
- Te Wiki o te Reo Māori – Podcast Recording | Filming and support for internal video celebrating staff reo journeys for upcoming Te Wiki o te Reo Māori

Māori Engagement support for:

Hapū/Iwi Engagement

- Hapū/Iwi Engagement | Ongoing relationship management and coordination across council projects
- Stormwater Consent Hapū Advisory Group | Continued implementation and live testing of the Māori Engagement System through structured hapū engagement across 14 catchments
- District-Wide Water Projects | Ongoing support for hapū liaison, engagement planning, and cross-departmental alignment
- Whangārei City and Whangārei Heads Wastewater Projects | Engagement guidance and coordination with relevant hapū on wastewater upgrades and long-term planning
- Whangārei Old Boys Site Project | Supporting internal discussions and future engagement strategy with hapū around historical land use issues and future development aspirations
- Papakāinga Fund | Internal panel support, refinement of eligibility scope, and clearer engagement pathways to enable Māori housing outcomes
- Gomez Dam Decommissioning – Hikurangi | Drafting of hapū notification and initial engagement on cultural values associated with the site
- Resource Management Consents | Support with cultural impact considerations, engagement triggers, and updates to hapū contact and rohe mapping data

Hapū Engagement

- Resource Management Consents
- RMA 101 training for hapu | underwent training workshops with Ngati Taka and Tuparehuia whanau
- Updating contacts and rohe mapping | Adding Whananaki Māori Committee to the weekly consent's distribution | Including Te Uriroi in urban engagement

Internal Meetings

- Inter-Council Māori Teams Hui | Continued sharing of Māori engagement tools, processes, and strategies with other councils
- District Planning & Māori Outcomes | Regular collaboration on Papakāinga Policy and coordination of hapū priorities across the district
- Water Infrastructure Projects (NRC/WDC) | Ongoing internal alignment on engagement approaches for water-related projects
- Engagement System Sessions with Staff | Supporting teams to understand and apply the Māori Engagement Hub and trigger process

- Papakāinga Fund – Internal Panel | Continued cross-team decision-making on fund eligibility and application refinement
- Ruakākā Wastewater Treatment Plant | Internal discussions on engagement approach, cultural values, and future hapū conversations
- Kōwhiringa 2025 – Elections Planning | Planning for Māori civic participation and internal coordination on voter engagement
- Review of ‘Mahere ā Rohe o ngā Hapū’ | Ongoing review of hapū rohe mapping and contact update accuracy
- Hapu maps and contacts | Consents admin are testing out the maps with the goal of further access across the organisation
- Tangata Whenua Policy Drafting | Collaborative review and refinement of internal policy recognising tangata whenua priorities
- Climate Change Steering Committee | Discussions on Māori inclusion and environmental responsiveness across council strategy
- Municipal Building Cultural Narrative with Hapū | Internal planning and coordination with hapū to shape the cultural narrative of the upgraded Municipal Building
- Operative sites and areas Mapping | Current sites need to be reviewed to be included/excluded in the ongoing plan change

Council; Te Kārearea | Standing Committee

- Support for August meetings (Hapū Hosted & Chambers)

5.5.1 Delegated Financial Authority Policy

Nothing to note.

5.6 Legislation changes or updates

The coalition government has progressed a suite of legislative changes that roll back key initiatives introduced by the previous government, many of which directly affect local government and Māori-Crown relationships. These include the introduction of the Treaty Principles Bill, the repeal of the Smokefree Environments and Regulated Products (Smoked Tobacco) Amendment Act, and proposed amendments to the Resource Management Act through the Fast-Track Approvals Bill. While the previous government prioritised strengthening the nation's Tiriti o Waitangi commitments, the current government has signalled a shift in direction, with a focus on redefining how it interprets and implements its responsibilities under Te Tiriti o Waitangi. These developments have implications for Māori engagement, representation, and participation in local governance processes.

5.7 Future Planning / What's coming next?

Ongoing development and improvement of tools, frameworks, and materials that enhance organisational cultural understanding, capability, and improved delivery.

RESOLUTION TO EXCLUDE THE PUBLIC

That the public be excluded from the following parts of proceedings of this meeting.

The general subject of each matter to be considered while the public is excluded, the reason for passing this resolution in relation to each matter, and the specific grounds under Section 48(1) of the Local Government Official Information and Meetings Act 1987 for the passing of this resolution are as follows:

1.	The making available of information would be likely to unreasonably prejudice the commercial position of persons who are the subject of the information. {Section 7(2)(c)}
2.	To enable the council (the committee) to carry on without prejudice or disadvantage commercial negotiations. {(Section 7(2)(i))}.
3.	To protect the privacy of natural persons. {Section 7(2)(a)}.
4.	Publicity prior to successful prosecution of the individuals named would be contrary to the laws of natural justice and may constitute contempt of court. {Section 48(1)(b)}.
5.	To protect information which is the subject to an obligation of confidence, the publication of such information would be likely to prejudice the supply of information from the same source and it is in the public interest that such information should continue to be supplied. {Section 7(2)(c)(i)}.
6.	In order to maintain legal professional privilege. {Section 2(g)}.
7.	To enable the council to carry on without prejudice or disadvantage, negotiations {Section 7(2)(i)}.

Resolution to allow members of the public to remain

If the council/committee wishes members of the public to remain during discussion of confidential items the following additional recommendation will need to be passed:

Move/Second

"That _____ be permitted to remain at this meeting, after the public has been excluded, because of his/her/their knowledge of Item _____.

This knowledge, which will be of assistance in relation to the matter to be discussed, is relevant to that matter because _____.

Note:

Every resolution to exclude the public shall be put at a time when the meeting is open to the public.